Sangha Teachings

Sufism: The Way of the Heart

For those who don't know me, my name is Ma'at and today I'd like to share with you an introduction to the magical, mystical, mysterious path of the Sufi

We'll dive into the Essence of Sufism and What it Means To Be a Sufi

I'll share these teachings through my own experience

So before we can discover What Sufism Is… We have to go on a journey to see what Sufism is NOT

If you are an Advaitan, you will appreciate this :)

My path of discovering Sufism was a path of Neti Neti…

Because before I finally discovered the Heart of Sufism

I spent years trying to glimpse into this mysterious and magical world of Sufi…

What is Sufism?

What is it not?

But before we start…

Why am I teaching this class?

From t - Sufi Mystic, Today

Sufism is a way of being with God

- God is the beloved
- Love affair

- The essence of Sufism
- A way to be with God through Love
- Greatest mystery that exists in our world, exists in being a human being
    - Mystery of our Divine Nature
    - It is veiled from us
    - We are Divine
    - We are one with God
    - And Yet, it is Hidden From Us

Core of Sufism

- Heart

Rumi - Shamz

- If these books cannot liberate you, then what is their purpose?
- Dead fish
    - Knowledge that you read in books
- Why read about it when you can live it?
- You can be with God
- That is Alive
- That is Burning
- Complete consciousness of your Divine Nature

Sweetness before Honey or Bee
Place where the two seas meet

Sufism

- In west Africa, Sufism is mainstream Islam
- Emporers, and Sultans
- Moghul Empire
- Sufism
- Naqshabandi - political party

Hazrat Inayat Khan

- Sufism

- The germ of Sufism is said to have existed from the beginning of the human creation, for wisdom is the heritage of all; therefore no one person can be said to be its propounder. It has been revealed more clearly and spread more widely from time to time as the world has evolved.

“The germ of Sufism is said to have existed from the beginning of the human creation, for wisdom is the heritage of all; therefore no one person can be said to be its propounder. It has been revealed more clearly and spread more widely from time to time as the world has evolved.

Sufism as a brother/sisterhood may be traced back as far as the period of Daniel. We find among the Zoroastrians, Hatim, the best known Sufi of his time. The chosen ones of God, the salt of the earth, who responded without hesitation to the call of Abraham, Moses, Jesus and Mohammed, were Sufis, and were not only simple followers of a religion but had insight into divine knowledge. They recognized God's every messenger and united with them all. Before the time of Mohammed they were called Ekuanul Safa, Brothers of Purity, but after his coming they were named by him Sahabi Safa, Knights of Purity. The world has called them Zoroastrian, Christian, Jewish, or Islamic mystics, and the followers of each religion have claimed them as their own. For instance, a Christian would claim that Saint Paul was a Christian and a Muslim that Shams Tabriz was a Muslim. In reality Christ was not a Christian nor was Mohammed a Muslim, they were Sufis.”

Hazrat Inayat Khan

- Brought Sufism to the West
- Universal View of Sufism

Sufi Orders

- Tariqat - Path
- Chisti
- Mevlavi
- Naqshabandi

Following Islamic Law

- Formalistic -> Shariya
- Not about the outward formalities, but inner state & relationship with God
- Ibn Arabi
    - Islam shallow
    - Islam = surrender

Maʿrifa

- Experiential knowledge
- Not conceptual knowledge
- Mystical understanding of God

Wali

- Spiritual master
- Friend of God

Qutb

Spiritual pole

- Once on passes, the next comes

Nafs

- Ego
- Lower self

Sufism

- Hard to label

Sufis in my family

- They were abused for their religion
- In the face of mainstream Islam

Inayat Khan

- Don’t have to be Muslim to be Sufi

The Greatest Show on Earth

Hi everyone, my name is Ma'at and I'm a steward here at the Mandala of Light and it's also my honor to be our school's outreach lead.

As outreach lead, I'm very focused on what makes our beautiful Sangha unique and special in the world. And one of those things is the promise of **the uncommonly fine life.** An empowered phrase coming from our root Guru – this is where we end up when we step onto this path and start to do the inner & outer practice. No matter wherever we are at when we enter – whether that's a commonly un-fine or a commonly fine life – we eventually progress to this place filled with inner and outer abundance, a.k.a. an uncommonly fine life.

And tonight, we've heard some beautiful Dharmic sharings and insights into how we can tune into cultivating this uncommonly fine life for ourselves.

So for this talk, I want to explore with you what comes next.

- What happens once we reach the place of an uncommonly fine life?
- How do we go deeper into our path when our life is already abundant?

Spoiler alert: this is the phase of Dharma I call **Putting on The Greatest Show on Earth**

But first, before we get there, I invite us all to take a moment to connect with where we are at right now.

So take a look around:

- At your fellow Sanghamates
- Up at the beautiful desert night sky

And ask yourself:

- Why are **you here**?
    - Listening to these dharma talks
    - Huddling in the cold desert night
- And why are **we here** as a Sangha – talking about abundance all-together right now?

Well, there are no coincidences and there's a timeliness to what we're focusing on right now.

So if we take a look at our own Sangha. Where are we now?

- Our school is open! Yay! And we have some new students trickling in

- And we've gotten to this place after successfully making the transition from a single teacher to a network of spiritual teachers. This is something that is very powerful and very special.

As part of my work as the outreach lead and also for my own marketing biz, I've had the opportunity to connect with some other amazing spiritual teachers and organizations… and I have to tell you: we might think that all these shifts and changes we're going thru within our Sangha is just for us… but I have to tell you that it's so much bigger. Our Sangha is part of something incredibly powerful that is happening globally right now.

A shift that's going on in our collective. Our Sangha as well as each one of us has a beautiful and unique role to play in it - whether we are consciously aware of it or not. So one of my goals in this talk is to help each of us tune this collective next step in a deeper way – because we are in a very exciting time right now… and we each have an important role to play!

- Recently I had the opportunity to be with a powerful & authentic spiritual master with a large spiritual community. She was sharing with her community that the time of the Guru is ending… and we are entering a time when community will become so important – and she invites her community to step into mastery. Become masters, she says. What would a spiritual master do?

  What I see is that in our Sangha, we have already been cultivating this. We just have different branding for it. We call it: the Sangha is the New Buddha. But really tune into that – becoming a Buddha is allowing ourselves to fully be the enlightened expression that we are here to be. There are so many Enlightened Buddhas in our school and many more on the way. It's one of the magics of our school.

- OK, so if we are this powerful school that could be a shining example in this world of a community of masters or an Enlightened network of individuals living & working in the world, then where do we go from here?

It's time for us to put on: *The Greatest Show On Earth!*

- When we have all of this abundance, the Dharma is now to share it.
  - This is how we grow
  - This is how we deepen.
  - Both into our collective Sangha Dharma and also elevate in our individual practice
  - This is where we get fuel for our fire of Dharma
  - Our school is here to support multiple generations of Enlightenment
- The Buddha says:
  - One who shares the Dharma, multiples their own light. Just as a single lamp can light a thousand others without losing its flame

Qualities of the Greatest Show on Earth

- This is not a show for your self - but this ***is*** allowing your unique light and Dharma to shine through
    - Trust yourself
    - Be authentic
    - Be true
    - Shine your light
    - Love yourself

- It is selfless to share the way. It is selfless to shine.
    - When each one of us shines, that's what makes our Mandala glow
    - We've been talking about this as an outreach team for a while now
    - It's like the white light of the rainbow – the same light that gets refracted through the prism
    - Turns into a rainbow of light
    - To be that rainbow, we need each one of us to allow this light to shine through

- Go beyond limitation
    - Is there something that holds you back from stepping fully into your light?
    - Fear? Hesitation? Doubt?
    - Go beyond any limited ideas of what you are capable of.
    - Trust your Buddha Nature
        - Tuning into mastery: What would a Buddha Do? What would a Master do?
        - Buddha: Janaka tales – from his previous lifes, sometimes an animal, sometimes a Bodhisattva. On his way to Buddha hood. He got there by following the Dharma. Following his Enlightened nature. Do the same

- Embodied Enlightenment
    - Freedom
    - Infinite Possibility
    - Expansion
    - Rumi quote: stop acting so small, you are the universe in ecstatic motion

- It's not a one-man show, it takes all of us dancing together
    - Trusting ourselves
    - Trusting each other
    - Doing the practice
    - Sharing the way
    - Example: like a symphony, each person plays their instrument, masters their instrument. Alone is powerful and beautiful and strong. But, together it creates something magnificent.

Inspiration for this teaching: I had a vision when we meditated together as teachers, of our Sangha in this state of dancing together in the desert – the second attention of the Greatest Show on Earth – and I want to share that experience as a transmission with you.

Now staying in this place of **The Greatest Show on Earth.**
Open your eyes and look around.
Let’s fast forward 5, 10 years into the future.
See this desert filled with bright new faces.
New dancers entering the show.
All of us, here together, dancing under the stars in ecstatic motion

Let's put on the Greatest Show on Earth :-)

Thank you

Teacher Training: Compassionate Communication

#dharma #teaching

Guiding Principles

Compassionate Communication

One of the most Essential Skills of our work as a spiritual teacher

Bodhisattva with 1000 arms… hundreds of those arms are related to skillful communication

We are tasked to take these high Dharmic truths, mysteries of the universe that can be confusing or complex and speak them in a way that is accessible, understandable, and can be supportive to the diverse students who show up in our class

There's many facets to it

So it's certainly a skill worth developing

And where we begin - is with Right Intent

Goal of teacher: support someone on their pathway to awakening

As I just mentioned, to not only be able to share these truths in a way that they are received

But also, to build trust so that we can serve as a spiritual guide, an ally on the path

Because when obstacles & difficult situations or conflicts arise on the pathway to Enlightenment

Which from experience, right, we know how that goes

Things come up

Things get confusing

That we can be there, to gently point someone to the path of Dharma, the way of Truth

So how do we do this? How do we develop this skill of compassionate communication?

Well… it all begins with listening

As Thic Nhat Hanh says, you can't have right speech without deep or mindful listening.

Foundation of all communication centers around understanding
1. We listen to understand
2. We speak to be understood

Deep listening or compassionate listening has only one intent: to alleviate the suffering of another

And if you haven't listened to his audio book: The Art of Communicating
Highly recommend, it's a wonderful and relevant listen if you're trying to work on your compassionate communication skills

Tara's beautiful teaching yesterday on Thic Nhat Hanh's communication mantras for developing Pure Connection are also tie in & are the right tools to help us build this skillset as well.

So when we listen with the sole intent to alleviate suffering, we don't listen with an agenda. We put down our stories and assumptions. And we are open to hear instead of just listening enough so that we can then tell that person what we think is right or what they should be doing.

When there isn't understanding, then what we say doesn't really land..

Reminds me of an experience I had when I first joined the Sangha & many Sanghamates were trying to help me by telling me what to do or what was right for my life - you know, with very good intention to help me progress on my path - but since there was no listening, they barely knew me, it felt off to me and I wasn't able to receive it.

But then when one Sanghamate took the time to listen to me, and hear me out, then shared advice that was very similar to what I had heard - it opened for me. And I still remember that interaction in a very positive light.

Humility, recognize that our perspective and viewpoint may be wrong

Ask questions & rephrase things back to confirm understanding

When you take the time to listen, you build trust. And then you are actually able to influence in a meaningful way

"People might not remember what you say, but they remember how you make them feel"

Recently, we had a student, who needed to hear some difficult truths to help her progress. We weren't sure if it was appropriate so we asked advice from a Sanghamate, and they said OK, you've built trust with her - so now you can tell her this and she'll receive it.

* 1. Is It True?
* Focus: Truthfulness.
* Purpose: Ensure that what you are about to say is grounded in reality and honesty.
* Reflection: Does this statement align with the truth as you know it? Are you avoiding exaggeration, deceit, or distortion?• Not exaggerating or embellishing. We don't dramatize unnecessarily, making things sound better, worse, or more extreme than they actually are. If someone is a little irritated, we don't say that he is furious

2. Is It Necessary?
- Focus: Purposefulness.
- Purpose: Determine whether the words serve a meaningful function.
- Reflection: Does this need to be said? Will it add value or clarity to the conversation, or is it unnecessary noise?

3. Is It Kind?
- Focus: Compassion.
- Purpose: Assess whether your words are intended to uplift, heal, or support others.
- Reflection: Will these words bring harm or healing? Are they infused with love and empathy, or do they stem from judgment or anger?

4. Is It Timely?
- Focus: Appropriateness.
- Purpose: Consider whether the timing of your words is right.

* Reflection: Is this the appropriate moment to speak? Will the listener be receptive, or might the words cause confusion or harm due to poor timing?

OBSERVATION: non-judgement observation of what's happening in the situation, purely what you perceive with your senses, no evaluation (without a right or wrong)

FEELINGS: brings you from your head to your heart, what's coming up within you. And communicating that to the other person in a way that invites understanding → Important: "It made me feel…"

—> judgement not feeling: I felt ignored, I felt disrespected, betrayed, criticized

NEEDS: The universal human needs that are unmet, that are driving your feelings

REQUESTS: An open invitation to connect, specific, actionable, and not coercive

The most important thing:

Waiting until someone is ready to speak & open up, gently inviting them and then not rushing them as they speak
Listening is easy when it's about a nice & happy topic
But it requires more skill & mindfulness when someone is upset

Thic Nhat Hanh says stay for as long as you can keep your presence, your compassion, your bodhicitta

If you can't or when you can't, it's okay to take a break and return. To ask, out of this intent for compassionate listening.

- I am here for you
- I know you are there and it makes me very happy
- I know you suffer and I am here for you
- I suffer, please help
- This is a happy moment

- You are partly correct

Misc. Teachings

🌙 Sufi Circle — Class 1: The Path of the Heart

Intro:
Let people in
Music background - Sufi Lounge

Sufism is the mystical path of the heart.
Its outer form may appear as Islam,
but its fragrance lives within every true religion and tradition.

The shariat — the outer path — prepares the seeker.
It is the purification of words, actions, and conduct.
But the tariqa — the inner way — begins when one turns inward,
toward the chamber of the heart.

The aim of Sufism is Fanaa —
the dissolution of the false self in Divine Love.
Where all separateness fades, and only the Beloved remains.

Every path has its own flavor.
This one is wine.
The wine of remembrance, of beauty, of ecstatic love.
It is the path of the heart of hearts —
the secret chamber where God whispers to God.

———

✨ The Story of the Moth

A moth saw the flame and said, “I will know that light.”
It flew closer and closer,
until the heat burned its wings —
and still, it went on.
Because to the lover, even annihilation is sweetness.
To disappear into the Beloved
is to truly exist.

——

Once a moth circled a candle flame.
The other moths warned, “Stay away — you’ll burn!”
But the moth said, “I do not seek safety; I seek the light.”
It flew closer, and in its final breath whispered,

“My union is complete.”

Rumi said:

“Love is the flame which, when it blazes,
consumes everything other than the Beloved.”

That’s what the Sufi calls ecstasy —
when what you thought was “you” burns away,
and only light remains.

———

🌹 A Poem by Rumi

“The minute I heard my first love story
I started looking for you, not knowing
how blind that was.
Lovers don’t finally meet somewhere.
They’re in each other all along.”

———
The role of the Sufi teacher.

Increase yearning
The spark
Fire of the heart
Engulf the self
Burns it to ashes
Fanaa
Nothing left but the light

🕊️ Practices of the Way

Dhikr — Remembrance.
To remember God in each breath, each heartbeat, each glance.

Sama — Listening.

To listen so deeply that the sound itself dissolves you.
It may appear as music, movement, or art —
but it is not self-expression.
It is selfless expression.
The echo of the One remembering Itself through you.

———

💖 What We Practice Here

Vulnerability.
Presence.
Devotion.
We sing.
We open the chamber of the heart.

The song we sing tonight is the same prayer Rumi sang,
the one that inspired the whirling dervishes and the practice of Sama itself:

La ilaha illallah. La ilaha illahu.
There is nothing but God. Nothing but the Beloved.
There is only the One. All that exists is God.

Every name, every form, every ‘I’ dissolves here.
In this remembrance, only Love remains.
Let the breath say it,
let the heart hear it,
until nothing is left but God.

🕊️ Inner Sama — The Listening

But after the singing, it’s beautiful to also enter listening.
When the final note fades,
invite everyone to rest in stillness —
to listen to what remains inside the silence.
That moment is Sama in its most refined form.
It’s when the Beloved responds.

After that

Another song

This one is in Wnglish
This is how it goes

I love you God
I love you God
I love you God I love you
And I thank you God
I thank you God
I thank you for all you do …

We will sing

Tune into the heart.
Let yourself Go

Birthday Sufi Circle

1. Divine Mother
2. Om Namo Sangha Ya
3. La illa ha illalahu
4. I love you God, I thank you God

5 min each —> 20 min

Sufism
Sama
Listening
Frequency
Let it open your heart
Sufism is a path of the heart
It’s a path of Bhakti or devotion

Rumi - lover and the beloved
Fanaa - the place where the lover and the beloved become one
Burn up the self in the fire of your devotion

Allow it to grow
To expandTo extend

WOUND OF WOMEN - CLASS NOTES

Men… Women… And the State of the World
Yin / Yang / Unity

To begin… meditation:

Red ocean expanse energy
Down through crown chakra
A pillar
Column of bright white light
And where your heart is
See these two energies meeting
Spiraling outwards
Absorbing everything

In your essence, you are neither man nor woman
You are the union of both
Luminous body of spirit
Divinity
There is no separation into duality

But, in the physical world:
Leading our live in the body of a woman.. or the body of a man creates certain situations and difficulties

That most people accept as “the way things are”
“Boys will be boys”
“That’s just how women are”

But as spiritual seekers on the pathway to Enlightenment
Understanding that we are not these limitations
Being aware of what might come up so we can notice it and let it go
Becomes very helpful

And so let’s talk about why this class is called Divine Feminine

Because..

In this world
Women have it the hardest

In truth, a spirit in a woman's body has a greater propensity for spiritual attainment
Yet, there are way less liberated women.

Why?

- Repression of woman's power
- Historically women have been repressed

Across all dimensions:
- Socio-economic - women paid less on the dollar
- Religion
  - Sufi temple
  - Buddhists: woman can become Enlightened, but cannot be a Buddha
    - Do a good job, in the next: Enlightenment / Buddhahood
    - Due to their body, is inferior
    - Even the Tibetan word for woman: "inferior being" or "lesser birth."
  - Hinduism: women below men
  - Many interpretations of the Bhagavad Gita:
    - Women "lesser birth"
- Sexual repression
- Politcal Repression

But here is the thing… this is just the interpretation
- In another interpretation: it is an inspiring message of unity and that women can also attain the highest spiritual goal
- In the Bible, there are many passages
  - His-story
  - His-interpretation

Not a reflection of the Truth that the Enlightenment behind the religion was teaching, but a reflection of the skewed ideologies of the time

Why?

The masculine aspect fears the power of the feminine aspect

The yin/feminine has a stronger inner power, stronger spiritual power

The yang/masculine, stronger physical power

Yin —> Yang

Spectrum
- Scotty dogs

- Have many friends who have scotties
- Spectrum from yin to yang
- Black male scotty —> White female scotty

Being born in the body of a man or a woman
- Physical Body & Subtle Physical or the Energy body is different

Fear of the masculine of the immensity of the power of the feminine
- So what happens is the feminine is suppressed
- Physical power suppresses the spiritual power

Right?
- All started back in cavemen days
- Woman and a man.. last piece of food.. they both go to grab it
- Man says “I’m bigger”, pushes the woman down and takes the food

Because of the masculine’s ability to suppress the feminine physically, it easily extends to other aspects of life
Man suppresses woman

And that’s the basis of the world we live in
Where there is toxic masculinity
Suppression of the feminine aspect

And in this imbalanced world
Right, created by this fear of power
And this suppression

Led the feminine aspect to have to try and find a way to navigate
And as we mentioned
Since it’s being suppressed
It found more invisible ways to express itself

Through subtler forms
Through manipulation
Through coercion in this subtle ways

Classic example this shows up is in sexuality and relationships
Women using subtle energy and influence to control or manipulate situations

For 100s / 1000s of years, the path for a woman to have a good life was to marry the right man

Even though things have changed
And this shows up to the conditioning women feel that they are not powerful, that they are weak, that they are dependent on a guy.. the path to power is in marrying the right guy

Women: easily give away responsibility.. “girls just wanna have fun”, wanting to have someone take care of the realities and feel protected & just play / have fun

I definitely did this at the height of falling into this karma..
And it’s true
No matter what
- Right guy
- Nice house
- Nice vacations
- High society
You won’t be happy
Manipulated your way

Women, we have to take responsibility
We have to be powerful and own our power

The other thing that arises from this is competition
Competition amongst women
Other women as threatening
“Steal your guy”

And the thing is, when it’s expressed
It’s not direct
It’s subtle
Passive Agressive

With your girl friends
Attractive man comes in
Wanting to make him laugh
Throwing friends under the bus

Women have a powerful subtle physical body
- Can absorb this spiritual energies and transform
- Kundalini moves easily in a woman
- So transmissions are easier received
- In the same way, the energy can also deplete easily
- Especially women drain energy in relationship to men

Women Energy Body
- Butterfly

- Expansive
- Suited to express power

Men have a more rigid subtle physical
- More structured
- It's more resilient
- It takes more to absorb the energy into that structure
- But once it's in that structure, harder to lose it

Men Energy Body
- Suited to express love and humility

Attachments:
- Men and women
- In relationships
- In emotions

Women:
- Start gaining our own power and standing in our power
- Supporting other women
- Beautiful network of women
- Women supporting women
- Breaking down these boundaries

Men:
- Delicate male strength
- Protection and compassion
- Not control or overpower women
- Even when it's coming from "chivalry" or trying to help

Exercise:
- Man & woman paired up as a team
    - With a computer in the middle
    - To complete a task
    - Most of the time it was the man

- But the man takes it
- Winning
- Taking the power
- Let the woman lead
- Let the feminine lead
- And then you'll be giving her power
- Subtle ways you think you're doing something good

- But really you're diminishing the power of hte woman
- That's the conditioning
- It's subtle
- You'll only see it if you really look for it
- It's hard to see
- It seems innocuous

I recently had a call with a marketing guy, he's a CEO
My friend and I built a lot of AI-based automation tools
And we were showing it to him

And boy, he had such bad male conditioning
But it wasn't intentional
He didn't realize

As one of us would share
I actually could see that he notice the power
And I could sense the fear
And he would interrupt
And make a joke

But it's very subtle

But that's the conditioning right
Men are told to "Man up"
Be a "real man"

Yes this is the gross example
Easy to understand
And resonate with
What's happening outside
In the world
In our experience

But in reality
All of this
Is happening within you

How often in meditation.. do you fear losing control and fear surrender to this powerful unknown?
And do you see the closing down or the mental force that kicks in to push away that fear?

Meditate
Go into beautiful bright perfect states of mind

We see beyond our karmas
See beyond our limitations

Tara
Kali
Dakinis

These are helpful things to be aware of

So we can

Today I want to talk about why the “Divine Feminine”… and the “Divine Masculine” is such a topic to discuss

Men
OBJ

OBJ

Bodhisattva Training Series

Envision a world
Where every being wakes up with one intent- to serve and alleviate the suffering of other sentient beings

Commitment to compassionate wisdom and selflessness

More relevant today than ever before
With the current state of the world
I invite you to live the path of the Bodhisattva

What is a Bodhisattva

Takes the Bodhisattva vow
An enlightened being who wins the lottery but then decides to postpone their ultimate liberation, Nirvana
The unmanifest
Until all beings go

Origins of the Bodhisattva ideal
- 500 years after the Buddha
- Mahayana tradition - great vehicle
- Hinayana - personal liberation
- Becoming an arhant, an enlightened being who would not be reborn in tot he cycle of samsara
- Mahayana - the liberation of all beings, stick around until all beings are free from suffeirng

Photos of some of my favorite Bodhisattvas

- Senju Kannon / Kuan Yin - China / Japan
- Avolikiteshwara - India
- Manjusri - Bodhisatva of wisdom, flaming sword
- Green Tara - Mother of Liberation
    - Fearlessness and protection
    - Princess who vowed to achieve enlightenment in the female form
    - She was advised by monks to be reborn as a man in her next birth to achieve liberation, she vowed to be reborn in every life as a woman to assist all beings
    - She who saves

But it’s not about being some high and holy figure

- Medicine Buddha - vow to free all sentient beings from illness
- Buddha statue I sat in front of

And you…

In this world.
We could use some more Bodhisattvas
And share the path of the bodhisattva

It is a commitment to universal compassion, wisdom and selflessness

But as a Bodhisattva in this world we need training

It all begins with compassion

It begins with ourselves

Bodhisattva vow

Bodhisattva training

Should you choose to accept it

Compassionate Communication
- Writing
- If we can't hold that space
- Purpose is to communicate with compassion

Purpose of listening - to alleviate the suffering of another

As soon as we're caught in a perception, it's better to stop

Zen:
Thought of talking
Or thinking
Should be cut off

Instead, listen mindfully to ourselves
Take a pause

It begins with the self
Pains and fears
Mindful compassionate attention to ourself
We're not afraid of being overwhelmed
We know how to be mindful
No longer afraid to be with ourself

If you cannot communicate lovingly to yourself,
Listen to your own suffering
You cannot do it for another

Even if you "think" you are

Pause and sit quietly for a few moments

We live alienated
From the earth
From each other
From our own selves

Loneliness

Touch the earth
Connected to the body
Connect to the earth
If we feel alone

Mindful walking
Can be a cure

When we transform our own transforming
Healing the suffering that was passed on to us
And also reflects the suffering of the world
And the suffering of others

But we can't really do that unless we understand our own suffering
Unless we can listen to
And acknowledge it
And heal it

How can we do it for the world
We might want to jump ahead
We have this beautiful intention to
Do something

Be someone
To help the world suffer less

Listening deeply

Marketplace
Even if we're not hungry, we eat
We consume to avoid

When we understand suffering
Compassion naturally arises
Love is born
We suffer less

When we understand the roots of our suffering
The way out
The way out is through

If we don't understand suffering
We don't understand happiness

If we take good care of suffering
We take good care of happiness

Lotus is born from mud

Energy of compassion is born

Communication

Not prove ourselves
Not make ourselves feel better

Freedom is the foundation of happiness

You can only feed one of the wolves
- wolf of understanding
- Wolf of anger
Toxic or Helpful

Take responsibility for our part in the suffering

Loving yourself is the basis for compassion
In bodhicitta

We shouldn’t be too sure that we understand everything about the other person

Do I understand myself?
Do I understand my suffering and its roots?

If we can’t accept ourself
Hate ourself
Get angry with ourself

Self understanding
Self love

When we understand, compassion arises naturally

Communicating with yourself

When we communicate
Be aware that our misperceptions there

One goal of compassionate cimmunucation:
To help others suffer less
Already contributing to more joy

Buddha inside each of us
Wisdom
God

Breathe smile and walk in a way that allows this person to express

When we bow,
Help the Buddha in him/her come out
Genuine intention
Concentration
Not just motions
A living offering

Communicate to be understand and to understand others
1. deep listening
2. Loving speech

Best instruments to restore communication

Ten Major Bodhisattva Precepts
These are often associated with Mahayana traditions such as Zen and are taken during formal ordination or practice commitments:
1. Do not kill.Preserve life and cherish all beings.
2. Do not steal.Respect others' possessions and resources.
3. Do not misuse sexuality.Honor the sanctity of relationships and refrain from causing harm through sexual misconduct.
4. Do not lie.Practice truthfulness and avoid deceit.
5. Do not intoxicate the mind or body.Avoid substances or actions that cloud mindfulness and awareness.
6. Do not criticize others.Cultivate kindness and avoid divisive speech.
7. Do not praise yourself at the expense of others.Avoid arrogance and self-aggrandizement.
8. Do not be stingy or withhold Dharma teachings.Share resources and teachings freely to help others.
9. Do not give in to anger.Cultivate patience and compassion, even in difficult circumstances.
10. Do not slander the Three Treasures (Buddha, Dharma, Sangha).Honor and respect the sources of wisdom and spiritual community.

BODHISATTVA TRAINING CLASS #2

Last Class
Bodhisattva Vow
The Great Bodhisattva Vows:
Sentient beings are numberless, I vow to save them.
Desires are inexhaustible, I vow to put an end to them.
The Dharmas are boundless, I vow to master them.
The Buddha Way is unattainable, I vow to attain it.
Right Intention, Enlightened Intention
Japan Trip - Chandra, Janaka “Bodhisattva: great being, doer of what is difficult”
Training: Three main aspects - Karuna, Prajna, Upaya
Sonten embodies these three aspects
Three aspects reflect the three chakras:
warrior chakra - navel, grounding practicality, power
heart chakra - compassion, connection, balance, love
third chakra - awareness
Not “saving”, but recognition
Sentient beings are numberless, I vow to save them.
Green Tara - the one who saves
It is not that I will save you, but that sentient beings, each with their own natures, can save themselves, can liberate
themselves.

Buddha story: Honey in a tree, surrounded by bees
Bodhisattva isn't the holder of the honey
Holier than though - that's just spiritual ego
Point to the honey
Know how to encourage the bees to move: don't injure the bees, and they don't get stung
Show someone how to collect the honey from themselves

Sanjusengendo - 1001 Kannons, army of Bodhisattvas

Main Practice that makes a Bodhisattva is Bodhicitta
- Compassion
- Action
- Leads to Awareness - Awakened Mind
- Daily Bodhicitta practice

Last Class: Compassionate listening
- Cultivating compassion
- Deep listening
- Right speech
- Go into more ways to make this real in your life

Next Steps:
- Bodhisattva vow
- Daily Bodhicitta practice
- Every morning or evening - share a bright example of embodying the Bodhisattva path from the previous day, reflect on a situation / experience where you could have done things in a better way, and reaffirm your vow
    1. Bright example
    2. Reflect

In the Last Class:
- Intro to the Bodhisattva path
- Recognized that it begins with being a Bodhisattva for ourselves, and for everyone else

We have a new channel
Thanks Amber for the recommendation

In it, to start, share - in your own words - your Bodhisattva Vow
Thank you Jiyati for sharing a beautiful example of this vow in our last class

The Great Bodhisattva Vows:
Sentient beings are numberless, I vow to save them.
Desires are inexhaustible, I vow to put an end to them.
The Dharmas are boundless, I vow to master them.
The Buddha Way is unattainable, I vow to attain it.

Bodhisattva
- Think of this unattainable, very high, realized beings
- But really, as soon as you take this vow
- You become a Bodhisattva

It was amazing, this past week - Japan Retreat
To see that shift / that deepening
As you know, we have two new names: Chandra, Janaka

Witnessing take these leaps
We heard the hardships they went through preparing for this trip
The tests life brings up

And they both made it

And it was the same here in Japan
Lots of difficulties

We were sitting in Kurama
Inner Alter
It's a magical place

And we did a meditation
Connecting to the 3 Buddhas of the temple

Three Gods
- Power
- Wisdom
- Heart

Three aspects to the Bodhisattva Path:
1. Compassion (Karuna)
2. Wisdom (Prajna)
3. Skillful Means (Upaya)

Focus on the Japan Retreat
Examples of the Bodhisattva path & bodhisattva way

- Sanjusengando Temple
    - 1000

It all begins with Intention

Bodhisattva's

Many different expressions

Chandra
- Bodhisattva
- Whatever it takes

Janaka

The Great Bodhisattva Vows
Sentient beings are numberless, I vow to save them.
Desires are inexhaustible, I vow to put an end to them.
The Dharmas are boundless, I vow to master them.
The Buddha Way is unattainable, I vow to attain it.

SAVE them:

It is not that I will save you, but that sentient beings, each with their own natures, can save themselves, can liberate themselves.

I used to have that
I was like I'll be in the UN
I want to save the world

But true Bodhicitta
The Enlightened perspective
Is to recognize their Enlightened nature

Who are "we" to save and "who" are we saving
Recognizing, despite cravings / delusions, we are Enlightenment itself
Our vow, our commitment is to awaken ourselves & others

In the Tathagatagharba Sutra the Buddha said it is like pure honey that is in a cave or in a tree and it is surrounded and protected by a swarm of bees. Someone may come along who knows how to encourage those bees to move away, so that they can take some of that honey. Then they can eat it, they can give it away. The Bodhisattva is not collecting the honey but they can point to where that honey is. They can offer some skillfulness around bees so that they don't

injure the bees, and they don't get stung, so then that person can go along by themselves and collect that honey.

A Bodhisattva is a person dedicated to awakening themselves and others. Sometimes it is used as a term to refer to a highly-realized being, someone who is almost a Buddha. At other times the term is used to describe someone who has stable bodhichitta or enlightened intent

A secret we have to realize is that this magic isn't about super-powers – it is the magic of having unrelenting enlightened intent (bodhichitta).

Each one of us should do what we can to bring whatever rays of sanity we can to dark times. We can't wait until we are perfect, or have more time. We have to act on our most enlightened intentions in daily life now. There are no small acts. It all adds up. So this bodhichitta way of being is a matter of discipline; a discipline of bringing constant vigilance to our actions.

Compassion (Karuna):Compassion is the foundation of this path. It begins with the recognition of suffering—not just in others, but within ourselves. As we open our hearts to this universal truth, we naturally cultivate the desire to alleviate suffering wherever it exists.
* Practice: When you encounter suffering, whether your own or someone else's, pause and silently affirm:"May all beings, including myself, find freedom from this pain."

Wisdom (Prajna):The Bodhisattva path is not driven by blind empathy but by a deep understanding of reality. Wisdom reveals the impermanence of all things and the interdependent nature of existence. This insight frees us from clinging and aversion, allowing us to act skillfully.
* Reflection: Contemplate the causes and conditions that create suffering. See how all things arise and pass away in a dance of interconnection.

Skillful Means (Upaya):A Bodhisattva learns to act with precision, choosing the most effective way to benefit others. This requires adaptability and a deep sensitivity to the needs of each moment.
* Question: What is truly helpful here? How can I serve without attachment to the outcome?

Right Speech

There are many precepts of the Bodhisattva
- Don't kill

But the most difficult and the most transformative, is right speech

Compassionate Communication

Starts with Deep Listeninung

compassionate listening

Listening for the sole intent of alleviating suffering

Right speech

“That makes me angry”
“You make me angry”

“When this happens, I feel angry”

And it’s something I’ve struggled with a lot
I saw how when I spoke
It created harm
Disonance
That in some way it was negative
Or bringing others down

That I couldn’t say it without reacting

So I stopped speaking
When we have this

I made a vow to myself
That I wouldn’t speak unless I knew it was Dharma to speak

I had so many teachings about this
Because sometimes I’d get excited
And share things & over share things
Which to me felt harmless

Why shouldn’t I share my joy and love
It had always worked for me outside the path
But somehow after joining
When id speak in this way
Without mindfulness
Without consideration

It created problems
My parents started to worry about me
Because I was over sharing experiences from my spiritual journey that they weren't ready for
I wasn't considering where they are listening from when I spoke
I was speaking just because "I" wanted to speak
I wanted to boast

And in right speech
A disciple of the Buddha does not slander

Mind discrimination:
Reading, writing, speaking

Brings us straight back into the thinking mind

Words rise with discrimination as their cause / the basis for words are concept

Going back to silence
There is a truth beyond words
Beyond forms

When you think you are RIGHT, you are WRONG

Right speech is abstaining from lying, divisive speech, abusive speech, and idle chatter. The five guidelines for well-spoken speech are: Is it timely, true, gentle, beneficial, and spoken with a mind of good-will?

Is it true?

The Four Gates of Speech in Sufism serve as a spiritual framework for mindful and truthful communication. These gates encourage self-awareness, ethical conduct, and alignment with divine principles in speech. Before speaking, one is advised to pass their words through these gates:

1. Is It True?
- Focus: Truthfulness.
- Purpose: Ensure that what you are about to say is grounded in reality and honesty.
- Reflection: Does this statement align with the truth as you know it? Are you avoiding exaggeration, deceit, or distortion?• Spiritual Insight: Truth is a sacred quality in Sufism, reflecting divine reality (Haqq). Speaking the truth nurtures integrity and aligns the speaker with divine will.

2. Is It Necessary?
- Focus: Purposefulness.

- Purpose: Determine whether the words serve a meaningful function.
- Reflection: Does this need to be said? Will it add value or clarity to the conversation, or is it unnecessary noise?
- Spiritual Insight: Sufism values silence as a powerful form of presence and communion with the divine. If words are unnecessary, silence might be the better path.

3. Is It Kind?
- Focus: Compassion.
- Purpose: Assess whether your words are intended to uplift, heal, or support others.
- Reflection: Will these words bring harm or healing? Are they infused with love and empathy, or do they stem from judgment or anger?
- Spiritual Insight: Kindness in speech reflects the divine attribute of mercy (Rahma). Sufis believe that words have an energetic impact and should be used to promote harmony and goodwill.

4. Is It Timely?
- Focus: Appropriateness.
- Purpose: Consider whether the timing of your words is right.
- Reflection: Is this the appropriate moment to speak? Will the listener be receptive, or might the words cause confusion or harm due to poor timing?
- Spiritual Insight: Divine wisdom often involves patience and discernment. Speech delivered at the right time has the power to inspire and transform.

Applying the Four Gates

When these gates are applied, communication becomes a tool for spiritual growth and connection rather than harm or division. This practice encourages one to embody sincerity (Ikhlas), humility, and self-control, aligning speech with the ultimate aim of Sufism: closeness to the Divine.

Practical Meditation

Before speaking, take a breath and ask yourself:
1. Is this true?
2. Is it necessary?
3. Is it kind?
4. Is this the right time?

This simple pause allows your speech to align with the higher principles of wisdom, compassion, and love.

The Seven:
A mind that blames, rather than accepts responsibility can not create the Mandala of Light. A mind that sees fault, rather than works for solutions, cannot behold the Mandala of Light.

If we're moved to lie, gossip, or speak harshly, we inquire: Am I stressed? Am I motivated by greed, ill-will, desire for recognition, or fear of rejection?

For monastics, any talk not associated with the dharma and the goal of the liberation is considered samphappalapa, a Pali onomatopoeia meaning idle chatter. As lay practitioners, we abide by a different standard as we engage in social conversations to build relationships. Still, it behooves us to be mindful of how we feed our mind: what we say and our media contribution and consumption habits. Are we rushing to fill an uncomfortable silence? Are we indulging in drama, getting riled up with our self-sense? Such engagements threaten to dull our spiritual sensitivities. A great acronym, from Jonathan Foust, is WAIT: "Why Am I Talking?" The Buddha instructs us to speak "words worth treasuring" that are of benefit and in service of goodness.

Is it the Right Time?

Even after meeting all the other guidelines, we still must wait for the right time to speak, especially if our words are difficult for the hearer. For example, we may need to have a serious conversation with a friend about our relationship. What we intend to say is factual, likely to increase harmony, gentle, and beneficial, and it will be spoken with a mind of goodwill. But if our friend is sick, it's not the right time to burden them, regardless of our desire to get the matter off our chest.

to four components: abstaining from false speech, abstaining from slanderous speech, abstaining from harsh speech, and abstaining from idle chatter

He avoids slanderous speech and abstains from it. What he has heard here he does not repeat there, so as to cause dissension there; and what he has heard there he does not repeat here, so as to cause dissension here. Thus he unites those that are divided; and those that are united he encourages. Concord gladdens him, he delights and rejoices in concord; and it is concord that he spreads by his words.

The teaching about Right Speech assumes imperfection. Our "mistakes" are a vital part of our learning. We need to lie, exaggerate, embellish, use harsh and aggressive speech, engage in useless banter, and speak at inappropriate times, in order to experience how using speech in these ways creates tension in the body, agitation in the mind, and remorse in the heart. We also discover how unskillful speech degrades personal relationships and diminishes the possibility of peace in our world.

Aware of the suffering caused by unmindful speech and the inability to listen to others, I am committed to cultivating loving speech and compassionate listening in order to relieve suffering and to promote reconciliation and peace in myself and among other people, ethnic and religious

groups, and nations. Knowing that words can create happiness or suffering, I am committed to speaking truthfully using words that inspire confidence, joy, and hope. When anger is manifesting in me, I am determined not to speak. I will practice mindful breathing and walking in order to recognize and to look deeply into my anger. I know that the roots of anger can be found in my wrong perceptions and lack of understanding of the suffering in myself and in the other person. I will speak and listen in a way that can help myself and the other person to transform suffering and see the way out of difficult situations. I am determined not to spread news that I do not know to be certain and not to utter words that can cause division or discord. I will practice Right Diligence to nourish my capacity for understanding, love, joy, and inclusiveness, and gradually transform anger, violence, and fear that lie deep in my consciousness"

4) Not exaggerating or embellishing. We don't dramatize unnecessarily, making things sound better, worse, or more extreme than they actually are. If someone is a little irritated, we don't say that he is furious.

Drama
There's a part of us that likes the story
Telling drama
Making things bigger than they are
But what's the intent

I've seen this in myself
I make my pain / suffering huge
To make the other person feel bad
That's emotional manipulation

Something, good Indian parents
Had to deal a lot with

But we see the effect that has

Right speech is the most difficult to practice but the most important

See what compulsively makes you speak
Choose silence
And you'll get a deeper glimpse into what is going on

No matter what we say, it will not be mindful, because we'll be speaking only our own ideas and not in response to the other person.

When communication is cut off, we all suffer. When no one listens to us or understands us, we become like a bomb ready to explode. Restoring communication is an urgent task. Sometimes

only ten minutes of deep listening can transform us and bring a smile back to our lips. The Bodhisattva Kwan Yin is the one who hears the cries of the world. She has the quality of listening deeply, without judging or reacting. When we listen with our whole being, we can defuse a lot of bombs. If the other person feels that we are critical of what they are saying, their suffering will not be relieved. When psychotherapists practice Right Listening, their patients have the courage to say things they have never been able to tell anyone before. Deep listening nourishes both speaker and listener.

Upaya

To descend, come down upon;
Skillful means

Teaching what is needed for that person
- Forms can look different
- But the key is the same
    - Alleviate one's suffering, awakening
    - Wisdom & compassion
    - Activity that helps others realize Enlightenment

Buddha
- Words are like a raft
- Used to cross the river
- Then abandoned
- Words themselves aren't the important thing
- Our teacher
    - One thing to one person
    - And immediately after, recount the same situation in a completely different way for the next person
- Why?
    - Not about the words
    - Words themselves don't have intrinsic value
    - The only aim as a Bodhisattva for the words is how they point to Dharma, how they help someone relieve suffering, how they help us with awakening
    - So don't get confused
- If you're in this community
    - And you see you that happening
    - Some people are treated in certain ways
    - While others are treated in other ways
    - It's not because of a like/dislike
    - It's the same
    - The goal is one
    - The forms are many

Parable of the Burning House - Lotus Sutra
- Story of the father
- Three kids in a burning house
- They are distracted with playing games
- He begs them to come out
- Telling them the danger
- For each child he has to say something different
- For one he says there is a goat cart outside
- There's a deer cart outside
- There's an ox cart outside
- Once outside, they received the gift of liberation

Work of the Bodhisattva
- Tricky
- Convince ourselves to leave our little pleasures
- Our limited highs & lows
- For a far greater vista

So we begin with ourselves
- Where can we apply Upaya
- Coaxing these different aspects into the light
- But remember, the key
- The goal is liberation, awakening
- When you open up something
- Don't fall into the story of it
- Stand in the light

Right teaching for that time, for that place, for that student
- That's why there are so many different religions
- When Buddha came
- He taught what was needed

- When Jesus came
  - People were living in strict Jewish discipline / moral law
  - He was focused on compassion, forgiveness, and love

- When Muhammad came
  - Tribal society
  - Lawlessness
  - Lots of feuds & moral corruption
  - So when you read the Quran
  - Strict laws
  - Intent was discipline

    - That's what people needed

- Temples
    - Hindu / Buddhist temples
    - Many gods
    - There are gods that exude compassion
        - Like Quan Yin / Cannon
    - Then there are more wrathful emanations
        - Fudo-myo-o / Makahala
            - Many arms
            - Carrying a sword
        - But in that wrath
        - Can be the most powerful gift

Now I'm not telling you to do this to others
Because if you confuse anger for wrath
It can be very harmful
It's best to practice Compassion on others
It all comes from compassion
So don't get angry and swing a sword at someone

True wrath is transformative power and are not rooted in anger or ego.
Arises from compassion and wisdom, aiming to cut through ignorance and obstacles.

Without full mastery over one's emotions, wrath can easily slip into personal anger, frustration, or a need for control, causing more harm than good.
I went through that phase
It's more powerful to be compassionate
& Be silent

That will build your discernment
Discrimination

Eventually use these methods

Reflection Questions:
* "What is my intention behind this action or expression?"
* "Am I acting out of love and wisdom, or am I reacting from ego or frustration?"
* "Is this action truly for the benefit of others, or does it serve my own needs?"

When things -don’t- go your way

#teaching #dharma #sufism

What to do when things don’t go your way

How to handle it with grace

Zen Story
- monk
- Tiger
- Another tiger is below
- He sees a strawberry
- Reaches out
- and he eats it

Mustard seed
- find it from a house that has not known death

Sufi tale
- bird trapped in a cage
- But the true cage is its own attachment
- Then it realizes this and it’s free

Prisoner of your own mind
- it’s not the external world

Our choices
How we respond

Buddha
- we are what we think
- Think or act with a pure mind
- And happiness will follow
- Like the ox draws the cart

Unconditional Love
- do we know what that means?
- It’s not just when things are going our way
- Fair weather friends

It’s a topic I’ve been exploring
- what does it really mean
- Unconditional

-

A Sufi perspective on handling things with grace when they don't go your way is rooted deeply in surrender and acceptance, often described as "Tawakkul" (trust in divine wisdom) and "Rida" (contentment with God's will). Here's a teaching approach a spiritual Sufi teacher might take:

Teaching: Embracing Divine Wisdom and Surrendering with Grace

1. Understanding Divine Wisdom
Sufi teachings emphasize that everything in life, whether it aligns with our desires or not, comes from divine wisdom. A key principle is to remember that the universe is always unfolding in alignment with a greater plan, one that is beyond our immediate understanding. When things don't go as we hope, it's often because there's a lesson or growth opportunity we are meant to encounter.

- Reflection: "This situation is part of my journey, woven by divine hands. What is it teaching me?"

2. Practicing Surrender (Tawakkul)
Tawakkul is about surrendering our will to the Divine and accepting that our limited perspective cannot see the full picture. Surrendering doesn't mean inaction; it means releasing our attachment to the outcome and trusting that what unfolds is for our highest good.

- Exercise: Each time you face disappointment, consciously release it by saying, "I surrender this to Divine wisdom," and focus on the lessons or blessings in the current moment.

3. Cultivating Rida (Contentment)
Rida, or contentment, is the acceptance and peace that comes from knowing we are exactly where we need to be. It's about being content, not because everything is perfect, but because we trust that there is a purpose beyond what we can see.

- Practice: When you feel resistance, try to turn it into contentment by acknowledging, "I am where I am meant to be, and I trust the unfolding."

4. Gratitude in All Moments
Sufi teachings encourage gratitude even in hardship, as it keeps the heart open. Gratitude helps shift our focus from what we lack to what we have, allowing grace to enter.

- Daily Practice: At the end of each day, list three things you're grateful for, even if they seem small. This keeps the heart aligned with grace.

5. Seeing Every Obstacle as an Opportunity for Inner Growth
When something blocks our way, it's often a sign that we're being guided to a different path. Rather than resisting, we can see it as an invitation to deepen our character, strengthen our patience, and grow in humility and resilience.

- Mantra: "Every obstacle is a gift, guiding me toward greater strength and wisdom."

6. Walking with Grace in Every Step
In Sufi teachings, handling challenges with grace involves embodying patience, kindness, and understanding. When we encounter difficulties, we practice not reacting from frustration but rather responding from a place of peace and groundedness. This aligns with the Sufi idea of "Ihsan," or performing every action beautifully and with mindfulness.

- Practice: When something goes awry, take a breath before responding, remembering that handling it gracefully is a reflection of your inner spiritual state.

Closing Reflection

When things don't go our way, we are being invited to deepen our relationship with the Divine. As a Sufi teacher might say, "Life is a journey of surrender, trust, and contentment. Embrace every moment as a guide sent by the Beloved, and you will walk with grace through every storm."

Unconditional
- when we are as accepting of trouble as we are of joy

Story:
fair weather friends
Friends we love unconditionally
Refine our love

- even there
- We want something
- There's an expectation
- A feeling that we get when we interact with them
- We purify ourselves of this
- It's not vilifying
- It's beautiful
- But to be content
- Regardless
- To love regardless

https://www.techofheart.com/2013/04/what-is-rida-perfect-contentment-love-of-beloved.html?m=1

Rida

Perfect contentment

Comes from trust in God

Sometimes it’s hard to accept

The Power of Positivity

#sufism #divinefeminine #teaching
Always Be Positive

What does it mean to always be positive and why

Our mind is shaped by our thoughts
Buddhism, the Dhammapada, a collection of Buddha's sayings begins with this:
We are what we think
With our thoughts we make the world

Dhammapada

We are what we think. All that we are arises with our thoughts. With our thoughts we make the world. Speak or act with an impure mind And trouble will follow you As the wheel follows the ox that draws the cart. We are what we think. All that we are arises with our thoughts. With our thoughts we make the world. Speak or act with a pure mind And happiness will follow you As your shadow, unshakable. "Look how he abused me and beat me, How he threw me down and robbed me." Live with such thoughts and you live in hate. "Look how he abused me and beat me, How he threw me down and robbed me." Abandon such thoughts and live in love.

This is the first thing Buddha teaches us in the Dhammapada

Other great teachers like Lao Tzu
Also share how our thoughts directly shape and create our perception and experience of the world
Mind is fluid
Takes whatever form we put it into

There can be two people waiting in line to buy a train ticket.

One of them can be impatient. Constantly the thought "why is this taking so long, I hate waiting in line" is repeating through his head. He's shifting and grumpy.
In this same situation, there can be a second person. Happy, content.
Is not bothered by the waiting.
Who is using this opportunity to listen to an audiobook, phone a friend, or just enjoy the silence and space of waiting.
So, it's not our external circumstances that control our happiness but our internal perception of them.
And what shapes our perception?
Our thoughts

Our mind

In a given day, the average human cycles over 6,000 thoughts
How many of us here know what are the most common thoughts our mind is throwing at us?

BE POSITIVE

This is where the practice of mindfulness comes in.
We can't sit in meditation all day so we practice mindfulness.
Observing our minds.
Being curious
Not judge mental.
We begin to understand our patterns and behaviors better
And then we can consciously begin to change them

Grooming our mind
Constantly hold thoughts that serve truth and awakening

Not Toxic Positivity

remaining upbeat at all costs,
often leading to the suppression of genuine emotions like sadness, anger, or fear.
it can invalidate our own and others' experiences, making us feel disconnected and even more burdened

Like the meme "this is fine"

True positivity

It is not about denying the difficulties of life but rather about perceiving them through the eyes of spirit

every challenge is an opportunity to grow closer to the Divine, to refine our character, and to deepen our understanding of the Truth

We are what makes us, and what makes us is good

Why Worry?

Do you have a problem in Life
Can you do something about

Yes

Then why worry

Do you have a problem in Life
Can you do something about it
No

Then why worry

The Buddha said, “Your worst enemy cannot harm you as much as your own thoughts unguarded. But once mastered, no one can help you as much.”

Zen Story
Story of the Zen monk and the dying plant
Master picks out the dying leaves
The plant flourishes on its own
Just picked away the dying stems and leaves the plant was giving energy

Attitude on the spiritual path:

- Postive
- Brightness
- Love for the light
- It’s not going to be easy, but we’re gonna try anyway

In Sufism… this attitude: Futuwwa - being a spiritual warrior

With oneself, it is to accept trials and tribulations in stride.

With respect to others, it is to hold oneself but not others accountable, seeing outward injuries as inward blessings.

With respect to one’s relation to God, it is to abandon means and ends, relying on God alone through the heart’s reception, not the intellect’s endeavour.

The essence (nukta) of futuwwa is that you do not see yourself being owed any favour, nor that you demand any right.

The Journey of Enlightenment
#teaching #dharma #sufism #divinefeminine

If I am worth anything later, I am worth something now
￼

Even as you are going through the difficult thing

Bodhisattva
Great souls
Doers of what is hard

A bodhisattva is a being who has attained enlightenment, but vows not to enter into final nirvana until all living things are released from suffering.

We don’t shy away from the problem

We face them

What is the easy and appealing route

That so many take

That we ourselves have taken

Is to ignore

To be ignorant

To hide from what hurts

To hide from what is difficult

Sitting in front of a statue of a great buddha

Teaching - Aug 16th

#sufism #divinefeminine #dharma #teaching

How to establish yourself in the path

How to keep going

Even when it is difficult

And how to not float away

When things are going good

There's this phrase:
- Buddha at the top of the mountain
- Beggar at the bottom of the mountain

And we flip between the two

What does this mean?

Sometimes
- When we encounter difficult thoughts
- Difficult situations
- Negative thoughts, feelings, emotions arise in our awareness
- And we believe them
- We give them power
- Then we are suddenly transported to the bottom of the mountain

Then the next day:
- We have a good meditation
- We are feeling good and positive
- We think we are the best
- Everything we say or do is perfect
- I am the Buddha
- Sitting at the top of the mountain

We go through these phases

The funny thing is in both sides it's our ego
The self that is judging

So how do we overcome this?

Equanimity
- Not getting on the roller coaster
- No matter if the ride looks fun, or if it looks scary

Equanimity is a state of psychological stability and composure which is undisturbed by the experience of or exposure to emotions, pain, or other phenomena that may cause others to lose the balance of their mind

There's a good Zen Buddhist parable:

A farmer has many horses that give him status and wealth. When other villagers go on about how good it is to have these horses, his answer is: "Good or bad, who's to say?"

One day the horses breach his fence, break free and run away. The villagers are quick to point out how terrible and awful that is. What a bad predicament! The man again answers: "Good or bad, who's to say?"

The man's son goes out and starts looking for the horses that have escaped. A few weeks later he returns with the horses along with a few wild horses who had joined the herd. The villagers tell the man how wonderful it is that he now has his horses back along with a few more! Again, he replies: "Good or bad, who's to say?"

A few days later, in an attempt to tame and train the wild horses, the man's son is thrown off, and breaks his leg. When the villagers hear about the injury they feel so sorry for the man and his son. How terrible! Once again, the man replies: "Good or bad, who's to say?"

The son must rest and recover and let his leg heal. During his recovery the army marches into town looking to recruit all able-bodied young men to fight in the war. Because of his injury, the son is unable to join the fight. That is very good luck, the villagers say. And again, the man replies: "Good or bad, who's to say?"

Through equanimity, the farmer stayed balanced

In life, we go through cycles, it's natural:
- Go through lows, difficulties, challenges
- Go through highs, successes

But when we don’t take them so personally
We are selfless

We don’t attribute the successes to our greatness

The failures to unowrthiniess or something we are lacking

Just part of the cycle of life

We can stay in a place of peace
Or balance

At Times It Is Easy and At Times It’s Quite Hard…

#teaching #dharma

Last Week

Intense Topic

Many felt left Feeling Unresolved

So I want to dive into that deeper

Because these types of open loops

Can be places that start to create suffering within us

Becomes something that is hidden in the closet

The elephant in the room

First I want to address that by saying

I’m definitely not perfect

I don’t have it all figured out

But what I do know in every fiber of my being

Is that this path is real

Enlightenment is real

And when you commit to the path

It has a way of working out

What you are going through has a purpose
Even if you don't see it from where you are

So even if things might seem like they are easy for me right now

Or that what you're going through is more difficult or it's different

To get to where I am, I've gone through so many ups and downs

And a good way out is compassion

For yourself

For others

And compassion is not feeling sorry for yourself

It's not pitying yourself or others

Or justifying

Compassion is a state where you roll up your sleeves and take action

Compassion brings understanding

Compassion expands our awareness

We care about each other

Care that the other is going through suffering

And we have an intention of wanting to understand

Wanting to support and alleviate that suffering

Avalokiteshwara

He is the Buddha

We expand our awareness

We start to look at things deeper

It teaches us patience

And it has a significant affect on

Bodhi - Enlightened principle
Citta - heart mind

Bodhicitta - Sanskrit
Practice of Tonglen:

Taking and sending

Start with that feeling of concern for another person
Find compassion
Feeling of care

Men… Women… And the State of the World

#teaching

Yin / Yang / Unity

To begin… meditation:
Red ocean expanse energy
Down through crown chakra
A pillar
Column of bright white light
And where your heart is
See these two energies meeting
Spiraling outwards
Absorbing everything

In your essence, you are neither man nor woman
You are the union of both
Luminous body of spirit
Divinity
There is no separation into duality

But, in the physical world:
Leading our live in the body of a woman.. or the body of a man creates certain situations and difficulties

That most people accept as “the way things are”
- “Boys will be boys”
- “That’s just how women are”

But as spiritual seekers on the pathway to Enlightenment
Understanding that we are not these limitations
Being aware of what might come up so we can notice it and let it go
Becomes very helpful

And so let’s talk about why this class is called Divine Feminine

Because..

In this world
Women have it the hardest

In truth, a spirit in a woman's body has a greater propensity for spiritual attainment
Yet, there are way less liberated women.

Why?
- Repression of feminine power
- Historically women have been repressed

Across all dimensions:
- Socio-economic - women paid less on the dollar
- Religion
  - Sufi temple
  - Buddhists: woman can become Enlightened, but cannot be a Buddha
    - Do a good job, in the next: Enlightenment / Buddhahood
    - Due to their body, is inferior
    - Even the Tibetan word for woman: "inferior being" or "lesser birth."
  - Hinduism: women below men
  - Many interpretations of the Bhagavad Gita:
    - Women "lesser birth"
- Sexual repression
- Politcal Repression

But here is the thing… this is just the interpretation
- In another interpretation: it is an inspiring message of unity and that women can also attain the highest spiritual goal
- In the Bible, there are many passages
  - His-story
  - His-interpretation

Not a reflection of the Truth that the Enlightenment behind the religion was teaching, but a reflection of the skewed ideologies of the time

Why?

The masculine aspect fears the power of the feminine aspect

The yin/feminine has a stronger inner power, stronger spiritual power

The yang/masculine, stronger physical power

Yin —> Yang

Spectrum
- Scotty dogs

- Have many friends who have scotties
- Spectrum from yin to yang
- Black male scotty —> White female scotty

Being born in the body of a man or a woman
- Physical Body & Subtle Physical or the Energy body is different

Fear of the masculine of the immensity of the power of the feminine
- So what happens is the feminine is suppressed
- Physical power suppresses the spiritual power

Right?
- All started back in cavemen days
- Woman and a man.. last piece of food.. they both go to grab it
- Man says “I’m bigger”, pushes the woman down and takes the food

Because of the masculine’s ability to suppress the feminine physically, it easily extends to other aspects of life
Man suppresses woman

And that’s the basis of the world we live in
Where there is toxic masculinity
Suppression of the feminine aspect

And in this imbalanced world
Right, created by this fear of power
And this suppression

Led the feminine aspect to have to try and find a way to navigate
And as we mentioned
Since it’s being suppressed
It found more invisible ways to express itself

Through subtler forms
Through manipulation
Through coercion in this subtle ways

Classic example this shows up is in sexuality and relationships
Women using subtle energy and influence to control or manipulate situations

For 100s / 1000s of years, the path for a woman to have a good life was to marry the right man

Even though things have changed
And this shows up to the conditioning women feel that they are not powerful, that they are weak, that they are dependent on a guy.. the path to power is in marrying the right guy

Women: easily give away responsibility.. “girls just wanna have fun”, wanting to have someone take care of the realities and feel protected & just play / have fun

I definitely did this at the height of falling into this karma..
And it’s true
No matter what
- Right guy
- Nice house
- Nice vacations
- High society
You won’t be happy
Manipulated your way

Women, we have to take responsibility
We have to be powerful and own our power

The other thing that arises from this is competition
Competition amongst women
Other women as threatening
“Steal your guy”

And the thing is, when it’s expressed
It’s not direct
It’s subtle
Passive Agressive

With your girl friends
Attractive man comes in
Wanting to make him laugh
Throwing friends under the bus

Women have a powerful subtle physical body
- Can absorb this spiritual energies and transform
- Kundalini moves easily in a woman
- So transmissions are easier received
- In the same way, the energy can also deplete easily
- Especially women drain energy in relationship to men

Women Energy Body
- Butterfly

- Expansive
- Suited to express power

Men have a more rigid subtle physical
- More structured
- It's more resilient
- It takes more to absorb the energy into that structure
- But once it's in that structure, harder to lose it

Men Energy Body
- Suited to express love and humility

Attachments:
- Men and women
- In relationships
- In emotions

Women:
- Start gaining our own power and standing in our power
- Supporting other women
- Beautiful network of women
- Women supporting women
- Breaking down these boundaries

Men:
- Delicate male strength
- Protection and compassion
- Not control or overpower women
- Even when it's coming from "chivalry" or trying to help

Exercise:
- Man & woman paired up as a team
    - With a computer in the middle
    - To complete a task
    - Most of the time it was the man

- But the man takes it
- Winning
- Taking the power
- Let the woman lead
- Let the feminine lead
- And then you'll be giving her power
- Subtle ways you think you're doing something good

- But really you're diminishing the power of hte woman
- That's the conditioning
- It's subtle
- You'll only see it if you really look for it
- It's hard to see
- It seems innocuous

I recently had a call with a marketing guy, he's a CEO
My friend and I built a lot of AI-based automation tools
And we were showing it to him

And boy, he had such bad male conditioning
But it wasn't intentional
He didn't realize

As one of us would share
I actually could see that he notice the power
And I could sense the fear
And he would interrupt
And make a joke

But it's very subtle

But that's the conditioning right
Men are told to "Man up"
Be a "real man"

Yes this is the gross example
Easy to understand
And resonate with
What's happening outside
In the world
In our experience

But in reality
All of this
Is happening within you

How often in meditation.. do you fear losing control and fear surrender to this powerful unknown?
And do you see the closing down or the mental force that kicks in to push away that fear?

Meditate
Go into beautiful bright perfect states of mind

We see beyond our karmas
See beyond our limitations

Kleshas

#yoga #teaching

Kleshas:

Buddhism & Yoga

- Skew our perception of life

Enlightenment:
- Seeing life without any mental modifications
- Without any filters of the mind
    - Filters: Looking at life with rose colored glasses

5 Kleshas:
- Ignorance
- Identifying with your ego
- Desire, or attachment to pleasure
- Avoidance
- Attachment and fear

Responsible for all the suffering

Skewed perception of reality

Piglet Story

Winnie the Pooh

Great story about Piglet that teaches this concept that I learned from my Enlightened Buddhist teacher
That really helped me get it. I'd heard it before. But when he told me this story. With the energy behind the words, I got it
I could see what he meant.

So here's the story:

- Pooh calls piglet and asks Piglet, hey piglet - can I borrow your ladder?

- Piglet says sure, I can bring it over to your house for you

- And so Piglet sets off, taking the ladder and carrying it over to his friend's house

- And as he does… Piglet starts to remember the last time Pooh borrowed his ladder and how he didn't give it back for such a long time

- And how he had to ask him for it

- And he gets angrier

- Because he believes

And when I heard this, I realized how I was doing this

- That I had made up a story in my mind

- That my ego had convinced me

- And I started to pull the different situations of my life to support this story

- And we start to see it more and more

For example:

- If we have a perception… for example for me, in a relationship - that the other person doesn't care because they're not expressing it in the way that I believe is the right way

- Then I find

This is how the mind operates

- When you are in love, you see that person's name again and again in your consciousness

- Keeps them always present in your mind

- You're looking to keeping that story going

Or the opposite

- You have a belief that a situation is a certain way

- Social anxiety: you might look in the situation after you share something, how are others perceiving it

- If you believe that your family doesn't care about you anymore: you might look for and notice the signs that support your story

- Convenient, ignores the opposite signs

If you experience:

- Everything is SO good or everything is SO bad

- I used to have this experience. All of life is with me. All of life is against me.

- And I'd find the evidence to support

- The funny thing is: the situation didn't change much in the outside

- Maybe there was just a work deadline or a relationship with a loved one that was stressed

- And so I started to see my life through the eyes of that stress or the eyes of that fear

- Believing it to be true, it heightens that

Learn to see your life through the eyes of spirit

But it can be hard to see, when it's something that we really believe to be true

So I want to show you:

- Take an inward journey with me

- And I'll show you how to see what a Klesha is and how to see beyond it

Catch yourself:

- Body is tense
- Mind is starting to race
- Feeling agitated
- Telling story: blanket statements one way or the other / definitive statements

- “He’s always..”
- “You never...”
- “I’m never..”
- “I can’t..”
- “It should be..”
- “It shouldn’t be..”
- “Impossible”
- “But I have to”
- “It’s urgent”

Ministers of the Mind

Three Steps:

1. Breathe
2. Notice
3. Let Go

Transmission:

ChatGPT Teaching Outlines

The Teachings of Ma’at

Core Orientation

Ma’at (born Nihala) is a Sufi teacher from Kerala India, raised in the USA who found her Sufi roots through an unconventional path of Buddhist Mysticism.

Born into a living lineage of Sufism in Kerala, the Naqshabandiya Tariqat – her great grandfather & great great grandfather were magical, mystical Sufi Saints. They performed miracles that got passed down in stories to her as a child. She heard of their great generosity and love for the community, and how they were able to bend nature in order to protect and support those they loved. But before she was born, they passed. And the lineage got taken over by a corrupt ruler, focused on money and transforming a Sufi community that centered on this path of love & openness into a closed cult-like community. It broke her heart.

Growing up in America, she was very successful. MIT, valedictorian. Very focused in the mind. Living from the mind. But something in her heart always longed for the true Sufi way. However, looking for it – she could only find people coming from the mind. Talking about the exact lineage - the break down of peoples names and places, but missing the essence of the path. The closest she could get were the poetry of Rumi.

It was only when she met an Enlightened Buddhist monk, a master of Buddhist Mysticism that she knew in her heart she had finally met a true sufi. Through the path of Buddhist MYsticism, she was able to discover her pathway back to her Sufi heart. Now she teaches as a Sufi teacher and also leads Spiritual Tech Systems – a non-profit focused on amplifying authentic spiritual voices in this world. Helping uplift the world, and empower people to aligned with their Dharma.

Having lived so much of her life from her mind, before discovering the liberating freedom of the heart. It breaks you free from the prison of the mind, Ma’at’s teachings are centered around the journey back down from the mind down to the heart.

Much of suffering comes from living primarily in the mind: analyzing, narrating experience, judging, protecting, and separating. The mind is brilliant at survival, but it tends to divide reality into “me vs. you,” “safe vs. unsafe,” “right vs. wrong,” and “worthy vs. unworthy.” The heart, by contrast, recognizes connection. The heart knows directly. The heart remembers.

The spiritual path is the return:

from mind to heart,
from fear to love,
from separation to connection,
from self-centered identity to embodied, unconditional compassion.

Awakening is not an escape from life. It is returning to love as the ground of being — and learning to live from that ground while fully participating in the world.

She teaches the Sufi Way, a pathway to Fanaa, or the total annihilation of the self in the love of the Divine.

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1) The Way of the Heart

Love as the True Ground of Transformation

A central teaching is that everything, at its root, comes from love — even what appears as hatred, cruelty, or aggression. When behavior is traced inward honestly, it is often found to arise from:

pain,
fear,
unmet needs,
and the belief that life cannot be different.

When a person stops believing life can be better, protection becomes their religion. Anger is often not “evil” — it is a guardian. It is the nervous system attempting to defend something tender underneath.

This teaching is not sentimental. It is sober, compassionate, and precise:

- The mind judges and divides.
- The heart understands and connects.
- Compassion does not excuse harm — it reveals its roots.

Key Teaching Points

- Every being wants love.
- Anger often protects pain.
- The mind reacts; the heart understands.
- Compassion sees the wound beneath behavior.

- Love can open the heart — but healing takes time.
- The practice is to remain rooted in the heart even when patterns reappear.

Practices

- When anger arises, ask: *What is this trying to protect?*
- Meet difficult people with curiosity rather than judgment.
- Speak from love rather than from being right.
- Return attention to the heart when the mind becomes reactive.

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2) The Descent From Mind Into Heart

The Sufi Orientation: Direct Knowing

A major theme is that modern life trains people to live “neck-up.” The mind becomes the center of identity: planning, controlling, interpreting, defending, performing. The Sufi orientation is the return to the heart — not as an emotion, but as a **faculty of direct knowing**.

The heart is not irrational. It is intimate with reality.

The descent from mind into heart involves:

- vulnerability (dropping the mask of competence)
- sincerity (becoming honest about what is true)
- surrender (releasing control as the primary strategy)
- intimacy with life (meeting reality without flinching)

In the heart, separation softens. Love burns away what is false — including the identity that believes itself separate, defensive, or small. The path is not becoming “more correct.” It is becoming more open.

A guiding phrase from **The Little Prince** is held as a core teaching:
"It is only with the heart that one can see clearly; what is essential is invisible to the eye."

Key Teaching Points

- The mind seeks certainty; the heart seeks truth.
- Presence is deeper than intellectual understanding.
- Love dissolves the false self.
- The spiritual path is a softening, not an achievement.

Practices

- Breath awareness in the heart center.
- Listening beyond words (hearing what is underneath what is said).
- Allowing silence after experience (letting truth settle).
- Returning to feeling rather than analysis.

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3) Remembrance and Listening

Dhikr and Sama as Living Practices

At the core of authentic Sufi practice are two inner arts:

Dhikr (Remembrance): returning to the Beloved again and again, through breath, heartbeat, prayerful repetition, and inner attention. Remembrance is not performance. It is reorientation — the return to the Real when the mind has wandered into separation.

Sama (Listening): the practice of listening so deeply that sound becomes a doorway beyond the self. Sama includes sacred song and chant, but it also includes the subtle art of listening into the silence after sound — where the heart becomes receptive and the inner world grows quiet.

These practices are not meant to create a "spiritual identity." They are meant to dissolve the false self into intimacy — until love becomes more natural than defense.

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4) Voice as a Spiritual Technology

Drawing the Voice Down Into the Heart

A distinctive transmission within these teachings is the practice of **bringing voice down into the heart**. Voice is treated as a spiritual technology: not a tool for performance, but a bridge from mind to heart.

Many people speak from the mind: fast, controlled, defended, curated. Many people sing from the throat: reaching upward, striving, trying to be “good.” The heart-path is different.

The practice is to:

- feel the heart center first,
- soften the breath,
- allow sound to rise from the heart rather than the head,
- let speaking become truth rather than strategy,
- let singing become devotion rather than self-expression.

When voice drops into the heart, several shifts occur naturally:

- the nervous system regulates,
- presence becomes tangible,
- sincerity replaces performance,
- expression becomes simpler and truer,
- connection happens without effort.

Voice becomes a vehicle for remembrance. Speech becomes a form of dhikr. Song becomes a form of surrender.

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5) Relationship as the Path

Compassion, Bodhicitta, and Communication

Awakening matures through relationship. A heart that cannot love people is not yet a free heart.

Compassion (and the bodhisattva spirit of bodhicitta) is taught as a lived practice:

- not “saving others,”
- but recognizing their inherent worth,
- listening deeply,
- and reducing suffering through presence, honesty, and care.

Communication becomes a practice of liberation:

- listening to understand,
- speaking to be understood,
- meeting conflict without collapsing into blame or superiority.

The heart does not avoid difficult truth — it delivers truth without violence.

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6) Alignment and Dharma

Unique Expression as Service

Each being carries a unique expression of light. Alignment means:

- living according to one’s nature,
- offering one’s gifts without comparison,
- allowing authenticity to become spiritual practice.

When people live authentically, they naturally benefit the whole. The collective becomes stronger as each person becomes more real.

This is why community matters. A true sangha is not uniformity — it is a spectrum, like a rainbow: many colors, one light.

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7) Anything Is Possible

The Great Show on Earth: Capacity, Belief, and the Universe Responding

A major teaching is the transformation of identity through belief — especially after the return to the heart.

Connection to the heart does not only heal pain. It also unlocks movement. It restores power. It awakens creative capacity.

This theme is anchored in formative experiences of rigorous achievement and high standards: valedictorian, MIT culture, and the deep internalization of a shared attitude that problems can be solved, that capacity is human, that persistence changes reality. Within that world, “anything is possible” is not motivational fluff — it is an operating assumption.

The deeper insight is that ability is not “special.” It is natural when belief is restored.

Many people grow up hearing:

- you can’t,
- you’re not that kind of person,
- you’re not creative,
- that’s not for you.

When heard young, these become identity. People stop trying, not because they lack capacity, but because they learned a false limit.

The teaching here is simple and fierce:
People become what they believe is possible.

And there is a second, equally important layer:

Once the heart is leading, life begins to cooperate.

This is captured in the line from **The Alchemist**:
“The universe conspires to support you when you follow your heart.”

Following the heart aligns the inner world — and alignment changes how reality responds. Not by magic, but by coherence: perception sharpens, decisions become cleaner, courage grows, opportunities become visible, and help arrives through people and timing.

This is also why the “Greatest Show on Earth” becomes a living metaphor:

Life is not a punishment.
It is a stage for awakening.
A training ground for love.
A canvas for destiny.

In this teaching, the “Greatest Show on Earth” is what happens when the heart leads and capacity awakens — when human life becomes an arena where love, courage, creativity, and service take form in real time.

A guiding line from **Rumi** names the scale of what becomes possible when smallness dissolves:
“Stop acting so small. You are the universe in ecstatic motion.”

Key Teaching Points

- Belief shapes identity, and identity shapes behavior.
- Limiting identities are learned — not inherent.
- Encouragement awakens capacity.
- When the heart leads, life begins to cooperate.
- Creativity and capability are human inheritance.
- The “Greatest Show on Earth” is heart-led human life expressed as love, courage, and service.

Practices

- Notice where the phrase “I can’t” appears — and question its origin.
- Ask: *Is this a truth, or an inherited limit?*
- Encourage uniqueness in others — it restores their possibility.

- Ask daily: *How can I be an instrument today?*
- Take one heart-led action and watch what responds.

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8) Humility and the Dissolution of the Personal Self

From Achievement Identity to Instrument

The path includes a critical maturation: the shift from personal achievement identity to humility.

Early conditioning often celebrates:
winning,
success,
being the doer.

But deeper awakening reveals that life moves through causes and conditions, through grace, through the Source — not personal ownership.

Humility dissolves comparison. It releases pressure. It returns the being to service and sincerity.

The self that takes credit creates separation. When this softens, action becomes lighter and more natural.

True confidence becomes impersonal: not “I am great,” but “Life can move through this.”

The Essence of the Teaching

If summarized simply:

The teachings of Ma’at transmit the return from mind to heart — and the return from concept to lived reality. They are not oriented around a separate God “out there,” but around the recognition that what is sought is discovered within: the place where lover and Beloved become one.

These teachings arise from a life shaped by two powerful currents:
the rigor of mind (achievement, excellence, proving, solving), and the deeper longing of heart (love, sincerity, direct knowing). The outer story includes lineage, loss, and the heartbreak of seeing a path of openness distorted into control. The inner story is the rediscovery of what cannot be corrupted: the heart as the seat of truth, and union as the end of seeking.

In this path, suffering is not treated as personal failure. It is treated as conditioning: inherited fear, protective identity, and a mind trained to survive by separating. The work is not spiritual performance or self-improvement as a badge. The work is the softening of the false self — until love becomes more natural than defense.

The movement is coherent and embodied:

- **Mind to Heart:** releasing the prison of analysis, judgment, and control, and returning to direct knowing.

- **Heart to Voice:** bringing speech and song down into the heart, so expression becomes truth, devotion, and transmission — not strategy or performance.

- **Voice to Relationship:** letting compassion become practical through deep listening, truthful speech, and the refusal to dehumanize anyone — including the self.

- **Relationship to Dharma:** living alignment as service, offering unique gifts without comparison, and strengthening the whole by becoming real.

- **Dharma to Possibility:** once the heart leads, life reorganizes; capacity returns; creativity awakens; help becomes visible; the next step appears.

- **Possibility to Humility:** as power flows, personal ownership dissolves; life becomes the doer, and the being becomes an instrument.

- **Humility to Union (Fanaa):** the end of the path is not a spiritual identity — it is intimacy so complete that the sense of separation burns away, and only unity remains.

The “Greatest Show on Earth” is the lived expression of this arc: not spiritual escape, but embodied awakening inside ordinary human life — where devotion becomes action, voice becomes remembrance, and love becomes the organizing principle of work, relationships, and service.

Three guiding lines are held as living instructions:

From The Little Prince:
“It is only with the heart that one can see clearly; what is essential is invisible to the eye.”

From The Alchemist:
“The universe conspires to support you when you follow your heart.”

From Rumi:
“Stop acting so small. You are the universe in ecstatic motion.”

In short: Ma’at’s teachings restore the heart as the seat of truth, restore voice as a bridge into sincerity, restore relationship as the field of compassion, restore dharma as lived alignment — and restore the human being’s capacity to dissolve the false boundary between seeker and sought, until lover and Beloved are known as one.

EVERYTHING COMES FROM LOVE

The Descent From the Mind Back Into the Heart

(The Sufi Way)

Core Teaching

Everything comes from love.

Even the people that seem the worst.
Even the people we call evil.

When you really look, you see that they have been deeply harmed.
Something in them closed. Something stopped believing that life could be better.

And when someone stops believing that life can be better, they begin protecting themselves.

Anger is usually protection.

When you notice anger in yourself, look carefully.
The anger is trying to protect a wound.

This is one of the main movements in my teaching:

the descent from the mind back into the heart.

The mind judges, separates, decides who is right and wrong.
The heart understands.

The Sufi way is the way of the heart.

The heart sees that every being wants love.
Every being.

Even the ones we struggle the most to love are often the ones who need it most.

This does not mean allowing harm.
It means seeing clearly where behavior comes from.

Story — The Ox in India

I was in India with my friend Ra.
He grew up there and understands the animals and the environment.

There was a large male ox. Big body. Large horns.
He warned me — they can be dangerous.

But when I approached, I didn't approach with fear or control.
I approached with just love.

No agenda. No tension. Just openness.

And the ox softened immediately. It came close and nuzzled against me.

That moment stayed with me.

Because it showed me something very simple:

beings respond to what we carry inside.

When we approach with fear, the world feels that.
When we approach with love, something opens.

This is not naive. It doesn't mean love removes all danger.
But it shows the power of the heart.

Story — My Uncle

My uncle became very angry and stopped talking to everyone in the family.

There was a lot of tension around it.

At that time I was learning bodhicitta, and I decided to practice it sincerely.

When I called him, I didn't blame him.
I didn't try to fix him.
I didn't tell him he was wrong.

I just spoke from love.

I told him I loved him.
I reminded him of his love for the family.
I asked openly, without judgment.

And I felt it — there was an opening. His heart softened.

But then something important happened.

The patterned mind came back.

The conditioning returned.

And this is important, because people often think that one moment of love fixes everything.

It doesn't.

When patterns are strong, they come back.

The practice is not to force change in the other person.
The practice is to stay rooted in the heart even when the pattern returns.

Main Teaching Points

- Anger is usually protecting pain.
- The mind reacts; the heart understands.
- Every being wants love, even when they don't know how to receive it.
- Compassion comes from seeing the wound beneath behavior.
- Love opens doors, but conditioning takes time to unwind.
- The practice is staying in the heart.

Practice

When anger arises:

Ask quietly:

- What is this protecting?
- What am I afraid of losing right now?

When someone else is angry:

- instead of asking “how do I stop this?”
- ask “what pain might be underneath this?”

Return attention to the heart and soften the body.

Essence of the Teaching

The spiritual path is not becoming more correct.

It is becoming more loving.

The Sufi path says:
burn away everything that is not love.

TEACHING OUTLINE 2

ANYTHING IS POSSIBLE

Belief, Alignment, and Becoming an Instrument

Core Teaching

A big part of my life was shaped by the belief that anything was possible.

My name means “winner.”
I grew up believing I could do things.

Valedictorian. MIT. Achievement.

For a long time, I thought this was because of my mind.
Because I was smart. Because I worked hard.

Later I realized something very important:

It had nothing to do with me.

I simply believed that I could.

And when you believe something is possible, you act differently.
You try. You persist. You don’t stop at the first obstacle.

At MIT, this attitude was everywhere.
There was this feeling that anything could happen. That problems were solvable.

And I realized — this isn’t special. This is teachable.

Many people grow up hearing the opposite:

- you can’t
- you’re not creative
- that’s not for you

When a child hears this at a young age, they believe it.
And they stop trying.

They live their whole life thinking they are not creative, not capable.

But that’s learned.

Anyone can change this pattern.

The Deeper Realization

Later in my life, something shifted.

I saw how the ego wants to take credit.

“I did this.”
“My intelligence.”
“My success.”

But when identity softens, you see something else:

life is moving through you.

You are not the source.
You are the instrument.

One of my favorite movies is *Brother Sun, Sister Moon*.

"Lord, make me an instrument of Thy peace”

That’s the shift. Not an external “God” or “Lord”...

When the ego stops taking ownership, life flows more freely.

Alignment and Uniqueness

Every person has a unique gift.

The problem is not lack of ability.
The problem is lack of encouragement.

When people are supported in their uniqueness, something opens.

Like in *The Alchemist* — when someone moves toward what is true for them, the universe begins to cooperate.

Living in alignment is the greatest gift you can give the world.

Because when you are aligned:

- effort becomes natural,
- contribution becomes joyful,
- and others are inspired to do the same.

Important Balance — Humility

At the beginning of the path, humility is important.

Otherwise the ego takes ownership of success.

I went through this myself.

Thinking success came from “my mind.”

But the deeper realization is:

it’s life expressing through you.

When this is seen clearly:

- comparison drops,
- pressure drops,
- creativity increases.

You become an instrument rather than a performer.

Main Teaching Points

- Belief shapes possibility.
- Capability is universal, not special.
- Limiting identities are learned.
- Encouragement awakens potential.
- Alignment creates flow.
- Humility removes the ego’s need to take credit.
- Life expresses through us when we get out of the way.

Practice

Notice where you say:
"I can't."

Ask:

- Who told me that?
- Is it actually true?

Support others in their uniqueness instead of comparison.

Daily reflection:
"How can I be an instrument today?"

Essence of the Teaching

Anything is possible — not because the individual self is powerful,
but because life itself is powerful when we stop resisting it.

Bios

WEBSITE BIO - MA’AT

From the Founder

My life has taken me across two distinct worlds. A trained MIT roboticist & McKinsey business consultant, I learned to architect systems before becoming an ordained monk & Sufi teacher.

48 Social brings these worlds together. I've seen brilliant spiritual teachers get overwhelmed by technology & marketing demands — blocking the full potential of their work. Yet with AI & technology where it is today, the barrier to authentic success is lower than ever... if you know how to work with the available tools.

A more conscious world doesn't emerge by avoiding technology. Nor does it emerge when powerful tools are left in the hands of those using them selfishly.

It emerges when aligned people step into power and use these tools in service of truth.

— Nihala (Ma'at)

The **Authentic Awareness Accelerator** is an offering of **SpiritualTech Systems**, a nonprofit organization dedicated to bring spiritual enlightenment to the world through technology and advanced systems.

✨

When Conscious Creators Share Their Light

Every teaching, every authentic message, every moment of truth you share from your heart sends ripples of uplifting energy into the digital realm. Your visibility isn't vanity - it can be done as an act of selfless service. When you're seen, your message reaches those who need it most.

🌱

When People Live Their Dharma

Our world transforms when individuals are supported to live in alignment with their purpose. When conscious creators thrive, doing work that serves both spiritual development and practical needs, they create abundance that flows naturally, building a more creative, prosperous, and awakened society.

💫

Technology as Spiritual Practice

We integrate Buddhist practices — meditation, Karma Yoga, mindful awareness, and Right Livelihood — with modern technology development. Every tool we create, including 48 Social, is developed as an act of service, infused with spiritual intention to help you share your Dharma with authenticity.

When you step into visibility with integrity, you don't just grow your reach or client base. You participate in the creation of an enlightened society. At 48 Social, we empower spiritual beings who uplift others so we can uplift our world — together.

BIO

You know those moments when you've done everything "right" — the degrees, the discipline, the achievements — and yet something in you whispers, "There's gotta be more to 'success' than this"?

Ma'at has lived that journey.

Born into a Sufi lineage in Kerala, and later graduating from MIT and working as a McKinsey business consultant, she has always walked between worlds — ancient mysticism & modern brilliance, devotion & innovation, spirit & structure.

After six years immersed in Buddhist mysticism, Ma'at found her way home to the heart-centered way of her Sufi roots - a wisdom that doesn't ask you to think your way to freedom, but to feel your way there...to let the heart reveal what the mind cannot grasp.

Today, as the leader of a non-profit organization and one of our meditation teachers, Ma'at guides people toward the sacred presence that lives inside everyday life — the quiet pull of devotion, the tenderness that dissolves inner walls, the love that reminds you of your own Divinity.

In her classes, you won't find abstract philosophy or spiritual posturing. You'll find a living, breathing path of the heart: one that invites you to soften, to listen, and to return to the place within you that has always known.

If you'd like to experience Ma'at's teachings, you can find her class schedule at the link in our bio ✨

#MandalaOfLight #MeetMaat #HeartCenteredPath #SufiWisdom #DivinePresence #MeditationTeacher #SacredLiving #ExperientialMysticism #PracticalSpirituality

Sufi Circle: Post Sign Up

Welcome to the Sufi Circle 🙏 A sacred gathering of mystics, spiritual seekers, and lovers of the beloved! ✨
In preparation for the session, please find a quiet place to join where:
* you feel comfortable singing out loud (singing & chanting is a powerful part of the session)
* you are able to turn on your camera (so you can be fully present with the group)
Sufism is a path of the heart & cultivating an inner yearning for the Divine (... or God, Eternity, Source, a rose by any other name 🌹) is key ❤️‍🔥

Before the session, take some time to reflect on what draws you in to this session and what it is that you wish to receive from it.

The more you can open your heart & your mind, the deeper you will be able to connect with the energy and the experience of the class.

Meetup - Sufi Circle with Ma’at: Experience Fanaa ❤️‍🔥

Sing. Surrender. Remember.

Does something in you stir when you read the beautiful poems of Rumi?
When you hear the passionate love without bounds the lover has for the beloved, does it ignite a longing that springs from the depths of your heart?
Have you tried before in vain to fill that void with relationships or distract yourself with worldly things… yet there’s still this part of you that seeks Divinity… that wants to understand who or what God really is… and yearns to be in direct connection & union with it - whatever “it” is?
If so, my dear, then what you may be seeking is the place where the lover and the Beloved become one
If you thought this was ‘just a Rumi poem’… there’s more to it than that. This comes from something real that YOU can experience.

Whether you’re already a friend of God, or someone new to the spiritual path - the Sufi Way takes you straight to the Divine, through the doorway of the heart.It’s accessible, it’s beautiful, and it opens you to worlds of magic, devotion, and Divinity.

If you’re ready to experience this for yourself, I invite you to join one of our weekly Sufi Circle gatherings.

ABOUT THE GATHERING
The Sufi Circle is a sacred space for mystics, spiritual seekers, and lovers of the Beloved.
Through Sufi teachings, guided meditations, singing and music, you’ll:
- Learn to open your heart to Divine Remembrance (dhikr)
- Experience what dissolving into love feels like
- Taste the mystery of Fanaa - the melting away of self in the presence of God

You don’t need to be a Sufi or follow any tradition — simply come with an open heart and a love of God (Eternity, Source, Truth, Love… or whatever word you want to call “it”) 💖

Sessions last about 45 minutes long and are guided by Ma’at

ABOUT THE TEACHER
Ma’at is a born Sufi of the Naqshbandi Tariqat, an ordained Buddhist monk, and a spiritual teacher. She’s the founder of SpiritualTech Systems, a non-profit dedicated to awakening consciousness in the modern world. Trained as an MIT engineer and ex-McKinsey & Co., Ma’at’s journey led her from the structures of worldly success to the depths of divine

remembrance. Her teachings bridge the mystical and the practical — guiding others to experience Divine Love & Freedom not as an idea, but as a living reality.

Join us weekly to sing, to dissolve, and to awaken the fire of the heart ❤️‍🔥All are welcome.

In each gathering, there is an invitation for you to taste the mystery of Fanaa - the total dissolution of the self in Divine Love

In this circle, we come together to sing songs of God, to dissolve into love, and to taste the mystery of fanaa — the melting away of self in the presence of the Divine. Through chant, meditation, poetry, and silence, we open the heart to remembrance (dhikr), allowing the soul to rest in union, peace, and joy. You don't need to be a Sufi or follow any tradition — only to bring an open heart and a willingness to experience. Join us weekly as we remember together — to sing, to surrender, and to awaken the fire of divine love within. ❤️‍🔥

Through chant, meditation, poetry, and sama (spiritual music), we open our hearts to remembrance (dhikr) — the practice of returning to God in every breath.Each gathering is an invitation to taste the mystery of fanaa — the dissolving of the self in divine love — and to rediscover the joy, peace, and beauty that are your true nature.
You don't need to be a Sufi or follow any tradition.Just bring your heart, your voice, and your longing to know the Beloved.

💫 About the Gathering:
Sufi Circles are weekly and around 45 minutes long
During the sessions, there is a guided

🌹 About the Teacher
Ma'at is a born Sufi of the Naqshbandi Tariqat, an ordained Buddhist monk, and a spiritual teacher. She's the founder of SpiritualTech Systems, a non-profit dedicated to awakening consciousness in the modern world. Trained as an MIT engineer and ex-McKinsey & Co., Ma'at's journey led her from the structures of worldly success to the depths of divine remembrance. Her teachings bridge the mystical and the practical — guiding others to experience union, freedom, and love not as an idea, but as a living reality.

Join us weekly to sing, to dissolve, and to awaken the fire of divine love within. ❤️‍🔥All are welcome.

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an open heart and a willingness to experience. Join us weekly as we remember together — to sing, to surrender, and to awaken the fire of divine love within. ❤️‍🔥

🌙 The Sufi Circle with Ma'at: Awaken the Fire of Your Heart ❤️‍🔥
Sing. Surrender. Remember.

Do you feel a quiet call within — a longing for something deeper than what the world can offer?Perhaps you've tasted moments of peace or love, but they fade quickly in the rush of life.Maybe you've tried meditation, mindfulness, or yoga — and yet, something in you still yearns for direct connection with the Divine.
You might be wondering:Is it possible to experience real joy, love, and unity while living in this busy modern world?Is there a way to dissolve the stress, anxiety, and loneliness — and rest again in the presence of God?
If so, you are in the right place.

💫 About the Gathering
The Sufi Circle with Ma'at is a sacred space for mystics, seekers, and lovers of the Beloved to come together in song, silence, and devotion.
Through chant, meditation, poetry, and sama (spiritual music), we open our hearts to remembrance (dhikr) — the practice of returning to God in every breath.Each gathering is an invitation to taste the mystery of fanaa — the dissolving of the self in divine love — and to rediscover the joy, peace, and beauty that are your true nature.
You don't need to be a Sufi or follow any tradition.Just bring your heart, your voice, and your longing to know the Beloved.

🌹 About the Teacher
Ma'at is a liberated Sufi woman of the Naqshbandi tariqat, a spiritual teacher and founder of SpiritualTech Systems, a nonprofit dedicated to awakening consciousness in the modern world. Trained as an MIT engineer and former consultant at McKinsey & Co., Ma'at's journey led her from the structures of worldly success to the depths of divine remembrance.Her teachings bridge the mystical and the practical — guiding others to experience union, freedom, and love not as an idea, but as a living reality.

Join us weekly to sing, to dissolve, and to awaken the fire of divine love within. ❤️‍🔥All are welcome.

YOUTUBE CHANNEL

Hello & welcome 👋 If you’re someone who knows—deep down—that you're here for something more...
That you’re meant to live with purpose, freedom, and impact—this channel is for you.

My name is Nihala Thanikkal, also known as Ma'at in spiritual circles.
I'm an MIT grad, former McKinsey consultant, now a spiritual teacher and President of SpiritualTech Systems—a nonprofit working to change the world through spiritual systems and technology.

But this space isn’t just about me.
It’s about us—a movement of mission-driven individuals ready to break through old paradigms, release toxic structures, and co-create a brighter, more harmonious world.

If you're ready to step out of limitation and confusion…
And into sovereignty, clarity, and a life of purpose & prosperity—
If you're ready to turn spiritual longing into grounded structure, and vision into action—
You’re in the right place.

Let's begin.

LINKED IN

It’s time to enter a new era—one where leadership is wise, power structures are balanced, and success is defined by alignment, not empty accumulation.
My mission is to support the emergence of this new world.
As founder of SpiritualTech Systems, I build frameworks that help awakening humans step into right livelihood—transforming higher purpose into sustainable income and impact. Our work blends ancient wisdom with AI and systems thinking to empower mission-driven individuals, conscious creators, and visionaries to thrive—without sacrificing their essence.
We make powerful marketing automation and strategic systems accessible to those on a mission, so they can scale their work and extend their light. We believe technology should amplify humanity, not replace it—and that systems built on truth, purpose, and spiritual clarity can help restore balance to our world.
At the heart of my work is a devotion to truth, love, and service.
I envision a world where:

- Purpose is the foundation of prosperity
- Systems are designed to liberate, not control
- And humans remember their divine capacity to create, love, and lead

If you’re building something meaningful—and something in here resonates—I’d love to connect.

True Success

The Secret to True Success

Description
In this video, Nihala, an MIT-trained engineer and former McKinsey business consultant turned spiritual teacher, delves into what it truly takes to achieve success. She emphasizes that success is not just about hard work and tenacity but requires understanding and aligning with your true purpose. Nihala outlines both the practical steps and the necessary inner work required to find lasting, meaningful success, using a swimming analogy to illustrate her points. She invites viewers to reflect on their own definitions of success and to balance intuition with disciplined action for inevitable success.
00:00 Introduction: The True Meaning of Success
01:26 Meet Nihala: My Journey to True Success
02:17 Defining Success: What Does It Really Mean?
03:15 The Two Key Elements of Success
08:22 The Missing Piece: Understanding Your 'Why'
11:02 Balancing Intuition and Tenacity
11:55 Conclusion: Your Path to True Success

What does it take? “Success Takes Hard Work”

Missing Piece

Inevitable

INTRO to Nihala

Definition:
* Success is the accomplishment of an aim or purpose
* A favorable or desired outcome“The attainment of wealth, position, honors, or the like.”

Two things:
1. Direction you’re swimming in
2. The tenacity and grit to go
Setbacks
Measure
Let go of your self

Open to possibility
Stay consistent

“Never give up, never surrender”

1. Some can’t muster up the energy
2. Or worse, they accomplish it, to feel empty

In both cases, it’s because they forgot one thing
And that’s why

Yes, have direction
But why?

I saw in myself
- House
- Partner
- Job

Stop and ask

What does it take to be truly successful?

Yes, we’ve all heard the phrase “success takes hard work”, but there’s another element to it that’s just as important - if not more so, and it’s a piece many people overlook and it can lead to some pretty unpleasant outcomes - because even if you put in the hard work and achieve the outcome, you may still feel lost, burnt out… or unfulfilled.

And if you are someone who is looking for real success in your life, the type of success that makes you feel Aligned, Awake, Energized, Fulfilled
in this video, we’ll dive into the steps & considerations to keep in mind that will make success not only possible for you, but inevitable.

—

Hi, I’m Nihala, welcome back to my channel. I’m an MIT-trained engineer, former McKinsey business consultant, and I spent years in the traditional “success path” before realizing something was missing.

That realization led me on a journey to discover what True Success means. Today, I’m a spiritual teacher and the president of SpiritualTech Systems - a non-profit organization dedicated to uplifting consciousness through systems & technology.

So today let's explore the topic of what it actually takes to become successful.

—

Let's start out with the definition of success. What does success even mean?
Well I looked at a few definitions and this is what I saw:
Success is the accomplishment of an aim or purpose
Success is a favorable or desired outcome
And the one I think many people associate with success: Success is the attainment of wealth, position, honors or the like.
This is one that's been handed to us by society, school, family, media and many of us have absorbed.
But if we stop for a moment, and really reflect.
Is that what success means for you?

—

OK, so now that we have the definition.What does it take to be successful?

Well based on this, I think two things:
One: Knowing the direction you're swimming in. Right? It's setting your course for your aim or purpose
And then, Two: It's having the grit — the tenacity — to keep swimming in that direction, no matter what comes up

That includes:
- Staying focused despite setbacks, big waves or currents that throw you off course
- Taking measurements to see if you are on course and then adjusting your strategy when you see you're off
- Letting go of the limiting beliefs, the dead-weights that are holding you back
- Thinking creatively to find innovative solutions —> when a ship passes by headed in the same direction, being humble and open ask for a lift
- Staying consistent in your efforts — because if you stop putting energy into it, getting thrown off course is inevitably. And it's easier to see that with the ocean analogy. There are so many factors outside of ourselves that are present. If we don't actively put in the energy in a consistent basis, we'll be like a leaf in the wind. And who knows where we'll end up.
    - Maybe an island
    - Or somewhere completely off course

So in other words:
It's doing whatever it takes

Or in the classic line from Galaxy Quest, "Never Give Up, Never Surrender"

And what I've noticed, in myself and in others, is that most people spend their energy focused on trying to improve number two but often unsuccessfully.

Many fail because most people can't muster up the level of energy and conviction needed to do all those things mentioned above.
It's not easy to transform yourself, right?
It might be exciting and fun on day one,
But on day 100, when you still haven't seen land,
When your muscles are tired
And you don't know how much further you have to go
It's not easy to keep going.

And the reason they're not able to muster up what it takes
Is not because they're lazy
Or they're not trying hard enough
It's because they are missing a key foundational thing.

Or if they do quote on quote succeed, it's empty success.
It's not fulfilling or meaningful.

And the reason for these two situations is because they've overlooked the most important piece of this journey that they're on

Why they are swimming in the first place
Knowing the way for your journey is so critically important

And this is what many people tend to forget
They don't really know why they are swimming in the direction that they are swimming in

You need direction — yes.
But where do most people get their direction?

From goals handed down by society.
"Success" as defined by external voices: money, fame, accolades, appearances.

And so people chase things — sometimes for years — only to arrive and feel empty.

Because they never asked:
"Is this goal even mine?"
"Is this direction aligned with who I really am?"

And I share this because this was my experience
I had these ideas of what I thought I wanted
A specific life

A specific partner
And a specific type of role
And then when I did the work and I got there, I realized I had no idea why I wanted it in the first place
And it was a shock for me

So if you're someone who feels stuck and unable to motivate yourself, facing burnout, this is where to begin. Doing the introspection.
Having the self honesty.
The authenticity.
To really dive in and see what resonates.

On the flip side, if you are someone who knows your why
You know your calling
You've done the deep inner work

But you haven't built the tenacity, the grit, the physical skills,
To be able to manifest it
To actually endure the swim, so to speak

That also won't result in success.

We need both elements

In my practice we call this balancing the first attention & the second attention

Where the first attention is the seen world, it's your reality
And the second attention is the unseen world, inner awareness

Balancing the inner and the outer worlds

You need both inner alignment & clarity
As well as outer strength and will

To be able to 1) discover what you are here to create
And then 2) do the work to create it

And find true success in the process

And if this message resonates
Please don't forget to like, comment and subscribe

Share this with someone who needs to hear it

You never know whose life it might change

“Your work is to discover your world and then with all your heart give yourself to it.”

You are someone on a mission
Someone here with a deeper purpose

Mindset Mastery Class

What is the first step in your success?

It takes two things

Knowing the direction that you’re swimming in

And then having the tenacity, the grit
To be able to swim in that direction

No matter what waves come

But knowing the why for your swim is critically important

That’s what many people miss

True Success

And that’s why you see so many “quote on quote”
Successful by society’s definitions of the word

Who are actually unhappy

On the flip side

If you have done the introspection

You know who are

What you are here to do

But, you don’t have the tenacity, the grit, the skills

To be able to manifest it

To be able to face what comes

That is also

That’s why we need both

In my practice,

We call this

Balancing the First Attention & the Second Attention

Where the First Attention is the Seen World

And the Second Attention is the Unseen

Balancing the inner and the outer worlds

You need both inner alignment & clarity

As well as outer strength and will

To be able to create what it is that you are here to create

But to make sure that creation

Is truly something that uplifts and inspires

You first have to do that inner work

Of opening yourself up

To see what is what we call “The Dharma”Or the “Truth”

The Way

And this is not a fixed concept

Or a rigid idea

But The Dharma is something that is living

That is flowing

That is present from moment to moment

And it’s something that you can tune into

You are someone on a mission
Someone here with a deeper purpose

Mindset Mastery Class

What is the first step in your success?

It takes two things

Knowing the direction that you’re swimming in

And then having the tenacity, the grit
To be able to swim in that direction

No matter what waves come

But knowing the why for your swim is critically important

That’s what many people miss

True Success

And that’s why you see so many “quote on quote”
Successful by society’s definitions of the word

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But, you don’t have the tenacity, the grit, the skills

To be able to manifest it

To be able to face what comes

That is also

That’s why we need both

In my practice,

We call this

Balancing the First Attention & the Second Attention

Where the First Attention is the Seen World

And the Second Attention is the Unseen

Balancing the inner and the outer worlds

You need both inner alignment & clarity

As well as outer strength and will

To be able to create what it is that you are here to create

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The Way

And this is not a fixed concept

Or a rigid idea

But The Dharma is something that is living

That is flowing

That is present from moment to moment

And it's something that you can tune into

Someone who is listening to my video:

Today's session is for those of you who are here with a deep calling

A purpose to fulfill

It's

Let's start out with the definition

What does success even mean?

Well I looked at a couple different definitions of the word…
* Success is the accomplishment of an aim or purpose
* Favorable or desired outcome
* the attainment of wealth, position, honors, or the like

What I found, is that success takes two things:
1. Knowing the direction you're swimming in
2. Swim there —> Having the tenacity — the grit — to swim in that direction, no matter what waves come

That includes:
- Staying focused despite setbacks
- Adjusting your strategy
- Letting go of limiting beliefs
- Thinking creatively
- Staying consistent
- And being willing to shift and evolve — in service of your deeper aim

In other words:
- "Doing whatever it takes"

“Never give up, never surrender” classic line from Galaxy Quest

But here’s the thing…Most people can’t maintain that level of energy and conviction — not consistently.
And it’s not because they’re lazy.It’s not because they’re not trying hard enough.
It’s because they’re missing something foundational:They never asked themselves why they’re swimming in that direction in the first place.

And this is the missing piece and where the disconnect happens:
We’re told that in order to be successful, we need to choose a direction.A goal. A career. A dream.
But where do most people get their goals from?
From other people’s definitions of success.
From society, media, parents, mentors, peers —We absorb what we think we’re supposed to want.
And we chase it — often with everything we’ve got.
Only to arrive at the destination and wonder…"Why doesn’t this feel like I thought it would?""Why am I still restless? Still searching?"

And this is the
And the reason they’re not able to conjure up this type of energy and conviction for the goal

They haven’t found their why?
Knowing the why for your journey is so critically important
And it takes introspection
Self-honesty

Because like in one of the most common definitions of success
Success is attaining wealth, positions, honors and the like

So how do we succeed?

Well,

You are someone here on a mission
Someone with a deeper purpose

Have to set goals
Work towards those goals
Measure them

Measurement is so important

Who Am I To Talk About This?

Poems

Poems
#poetry

A Single Blade of Grass

Look and you shall witness,
The rolling field that lies,
Over in the distance,
Down where the sparrows cry.

This field is one with carpet,
Soft, smooth, in shades of green,
Comprised of elfish blades of grass,
So small they can't be seen.

Amongst this I am hidden,
My stature shall surprise,
For those who know that I am grass,
Still can't see me with their eyes.

And every time the wind blows,
With each single gust that's made,
I rejoice with all my neighbors,
And dance with every blade.

Wherever it may take me,
The direction that I turn,
I flow to where the wind goes,
A solemn trick I've learned.

Rather than be noticed,
I escape within the mass,
I am one among the multitude,
A single blade of grass.

OBJ

9/17

Once connected, as the tides recede,
Divides, and falls, into scattered beads..
Littered amongst the sandy shores,
Yearning to touch but can no more.

Patiently wait for the time to come,
When once again they'll all be one.

Ogunquit, ME

9/18
—
The last rays of sun, in glimmering lights,
Dance across waves to kiss us good night.

As the sun sets, bidding farewell to the day,
Knows the time has now come; it can no longer stay.

And to appease our sorrows in saying goodbye,
Paints magnificent orange across the night sky.

But the waves do not mourn, nor change their track,
They ebb and they flow, knowing the sun always comes back.

Hawaii .. 2017

——

Rain drops on a window pane
Awaiting sudden death
Cling on for life, a risky state
Fate determined by a breath
They plop and prod as raindrops fall
Changing shape and size
But what happens next you may not guess
May take you by surprise
A kamakaze rain drop
Decides to start the stream
It quivers for a minute
Entranced by fear and dreams
And then that fateful moment
It takes its fate by storm
The drop becomes a river
Plunging downwards towards the floor
It gives no hesitation

Once the journey has begun
Continues towards its destiny
Until its life is done.

—Sitting in a car on a rainy day

OBJ

Half Moon Bay 11/16/19
OBJ

What is a wave but a life..
Forming from the vast wisdom of the ocean,
Mistakenly thinking of itself as one..
At its peak rushing.. rushing to find some truth
Not realizing it is always connected to the source
Moves faster and faster seeking something that is hidden inside..
But whether it tumbles slowly or crashes hard.. at the end awaits..
A reunion that ends one but returns to all...
Back to the collective stillness of the ocean.

What is a wave, but a life,
Formed from the infinite wisdom of the ocean waters.
Mistakenly, it sees itself as one -
At its peak, rushing … rushing to find some Truth.
Not realizing it has always been connected to the source,
It moves faster and faster seeking something hidden inside.
But whether it tumbles slowly or crashes hard,
At the end awaits..
A reunion that ends one but returns to all,
Back to the collective stillness of the ocean.

12/20 - pre desert trip - torrey pines state park

Each blade of grass containing the infinite wisdom of the universe,
Only revealing itself to those still enough to see it.

12/22 - Del Mar Beach - ecstatic ocean

Many walk the golden border,
While dogs and children play,
This one odd group sets off for the wavy bay.
It's as if they cut across
dimensions of space and time,
Responding to the ocean's call
In a direct straight line.
As they reach the ocean waves
ecstasy erupts,
They play and dance as in a trance,
that nothing can corrupt.
Those on the shore continue on,
a few do lift their heads,
But most go on not noticing,
as if they're still in bed.

Just a bit of motivation for my soul:
Be strong. Be powerful. Not for yourself, but for others. Let the light of eternity shine through you so others can shine too.

12/26

Your body is the temple,
And your mind is the light,
Purify both to stay happy and bright.

12/29

I've sat in the night of the desert
Explored the deep blues of Bonaire
And truths that I have witnessed
Are truths that could cause one to scare.
And this mystery has opened
As my heart begins to pound,
This earth is not what I once knew,
But I know the truth is sound.
I've found my long lost teacher,
The one who shows the way.

He shares the light to make us bright,
When things feel dim and gray.
With his selfless giving,
I begin to see the path.
And nothing in these endless worlds,
Is worth more to me than that.

🙏✨ thank you my Ajahn ✨🙏

8/16

The light which you seek, it is not meek,
You carry it within, and it never grows dim.
You'll find it inside, though sometimes it may hide,

Look with your heart, and not with your mind.
To all beings around, do your best to be kind.
With attention like this, compassion will grow.
And through meditation, awareness you'll know.
There is nothing to sorrow and no body to blame,
It's a world filled with light, such a wonderous game.

A life that's worth living, a life that is bright.
That my dear friend is a life in the light.

Mauna Kea - Dec 8th

The Dharma...

Like sweet drops of honey
in a barren mouth
Singing songs of surrender
that echo in the hill

A freedom once known,
then forgotten

Now returns

Building a home inside
That cannot be destroyed
——

Dec 28th

If I am to sleep, then every dream that I have shall be of you.
And when I awaken, I shall greet you.

——

Jan 21st

In every moment, let there be light,
In every breath, an act of surrender,
In every heart, a beating for the truth,
In every smile, a glimpse of the radiance within,
In every tear, let the forgotten shed their woes,
And let every dance be a dance with the Beloved.

——

June 2021

Words simply just cannot express,
This inner, true deep happiness.

☺

-

I’m in love with the sky
With the birds and the bees
I’m in love with the way
The wind blows through the trees
I’m in love with the oceans
With it’s many shades of blue
I’m in love with the people
Whose eyes sparkle true
I’m in love with the sun

Whose golden rays warm my skin
I'm in love with all things
And this body I live in
I'm in love with the rain
With the smell of fresh dew
Alas, my beloved, I'm in love with you.

♥

OBJ

.:. The Dark .:.

The darkest nights
Cannot make me forget
The warm light of the sun.

—

07.21.21

OBJ

I listen, I wait

We live in the world
In the world, big and vast.
Where time can move slow
And our thoughts move quite fast.

In this world we are given
The ability -
To choose what we do
And to choose who to be.

With this freedom of choice
I do not want to stray
Please allow me to follow
And be in Your Way.

But when a decision arises
And the Way is not clear

Then what can I do?
When Your voice I can’t hear.

So I lay down before You,
I ask and I wait.
Patience I hear -
Enters through Heaven’s gate.

I’m listening now
So please send me a sign.
That I can see in my heart
Is truly Divine.

The Rainbow

Is it not the most wonderful thing
When drops of clear water
Transform into an assortment
Of dazzling lights
Painted across the sky?

And to create this magic?
A shining bright light that hit the drops just right -
Awakening a potential that sat dormant.

—-

.:. Your Wonder .:.

To sit in your wonder
And to gaze through your eyes
To discover new worlds
Filled with love and surprise.

There is nothing quite like
The presence you bring.
I see the world without,
And I see Truth within.

—

04/2022

OBJ

Difficult Times

At times it is easy
And at times it’s quite hard
To hold only the Truth
In the highest regard.

Voices come to distract us
Their temptations are great
They pull away focus
Yet another click-bait.

With our attention diverted,
We can fall into fear,
Desires… Illusions
We forget what’s most dear.

And instead we go chasing,
With no end in sight,
Running round in our circles,
We forget Divine Light.

But the Light never leaves us,
The Truth cannot be lost,
If we look towards or away,
What we see, that’s the cost.

So, make this choice for yourself,
Friend, what do you see?
Your desires, illusions…
Or perfect Divinity.

—-

Spiritual Ego

I don’t know that I’m in it

I don’t know how to get out
But when I’m there, I scream and shout
What am I screaming
What voice is the Truth
Being deceived, thinking I’m acute

___

Healing
May 1, 2022

How deep is this wound?
How far does it go?
The aches and the pains
In my heart surely show
God, please lift up this burden
I can’t hold the weight
I’m crushed by the suffering
Inside me, so great…

…Don’t you worry my child
You’re on the right path
These pains and these hursts
Are soon a thing of the past
One step at a time
Learn to open your heart
Turning pain into love
That’s where it all starts

Every time you feel pain
Do not run, do not hide
Instead turn to face it
With your embrace smiling wide
This love and this care
That you share from your heart
This is the True journey
Of which we’re all part.

—-

The Dance
May 1, 2022

Let me dance in your wonder
Explore all your planes
Your beauty - So brilliant
It does not need a name.
Spinning and twirling
With no end in sight
This dance, is the dance
Within Divine Light.

—-

Gentleness
May 1, 2022

Hold me - so gently,
with tender, and care
And I'll show you a love
that has always been there.

—-

First Kiss
May 1, 2022

I'm lost in your love
Enraptured in bliss
This, my sweet darling,
Is True Love's first kiss.

—-

Home
Sept 15, 2022

When you've found your way back
To this place that you know
In your heart is the One,
Is the place known as Home.

Varanasi roof
Oct 16

Don’t you see
My dear child
Try and try and try
Though you might

This world is not you
Is not yours
For the fight

Do not waste your time
Do not waste your might

Instead, dive down deep
Find the Truth
Divine Light

What is it
Oct 22, 2024 - Kyoto, after Kurama fire festival

What is it my darling
That weighs on your heart
That makes you feel small
That makes you feel dark
Like you simply no longer are hitting the mark

Don’t be troubled my dear
You are doing just fine
These thoughts passing through you
They are all, the Divine

No matter their flavor
No matter their shape
They simply can’t hold you
There is no-thing to break
So please my dear darling
Don’t make that mistake

To believe in your thoughts
To give them your worth

To toss you and turn you
And make you feel like the worst
Because no, my sweet love, you are not a curse

Rather, you are, the opposite you see
You're a beautiful spirit
Luminous and free
This body's not yours
This mind that you think
Is you as you know it
Will be gone in a blink

And then what remains
Is a field of white light
A luminous field
That glows ever so bright

Expansive and vast
Where you can Eternally Be
A beautiful place
Beyond what you think of as"me"

Beyond it's stories and tales
Of great successes and sorrows
Of its bags from the past
And its dreams of tomorrow

So it's time to let go
Of this"self" you hold dear
Come along, my sweet darling
There is nothing to fear
Eternity awaits you, and oh, it's so near :-)

Secrets
Finished Oct 22, 2024 - Kyoto

Searching for secrets?
Seek within, not without
The mystery is hidden
Is shrouded by doubt

Let your thought go
So clarity comes
Simply stay here
And you'll know where you're from

Why cling
Finished Oct 22, 2024 - Kyoto

Why do you cling
Do you hide
Do you fear
When surrounding you
Completely
Is the Divine
My sweet dear

Drop
Finished Oct 22, 2024 - Kyoto

You forgo
The entire ocean
For a single drop.

Yes,
It reflects
…Some beauty
…Some joy.

Held
In the right light
A mirror of its source
Yet limited in nature.

Why not
Let the drop go.

And
Embrace
…The might

…The depth
…The power
Of the ocean.

For that
Is your Home.

It’s Time
Finished Oct 22, 2024 - Kyoto

Time to lay down your arms
To put your swords at bay
To rest easy knowing
That God always stays.

I’m Here
Oct 19. 2023 - Sonoma

Do not worry.
Do not fear.

Because my dear,
I’m always near.

Closer than a breath away-
Simply stay, just simply stay.
And you shall know,
You cannot stray.

Mar 3, 2024

Freedom From Thought

These pesky thoughts, they are not real.
Doesn’t matter what they say.
Nor does it matter how they feel.
And give no care to what’s the deal

They slyly offer up, saying “hey, this is a steal”

Say, I’d rather let them go
Say, I’d rather let them be
And in my own awareness
I want to finally be free

So when they come and push
And when they pull with all their might
Trynna drag you in, to another endless fight

Know they have no power
Know they have no say
Only what you give them
In any moment of the day

So take your power back
Do not fall for their loud cheers
For their doubts or their desires
And certainly not their fears

Trying to convince you
Trynna get their way
Drawing your attention in
Do not falter, do not sway

Stand where you are standing
Don’t move a muscle or an inch
Even if they torment you
Pinch by pinch by pinch

Let them do their worst
And let them know you’re not afraid
You’re the grace of Light behind this life
And you’re not looking for a trade

And then what you will notice
When you start to pay no mind
Their power will diminish
And lessen will their bind

You’ll have room to start to wiggle
To move your fingers and your toes
Space to look around

And hear new sounds
For that's how this whole thing goes.

The day you make this choice
The choice to finally be free.
Is the day when you will realize
Who you are and how to be

Koan
July 20, 2024

If I am, then so are you
And I am, so you are too

If you are, then so am I
And you are, I cannot deny

If I am not, there's no more you
But can this be? Can this be True?

If you are not, then there's no me
To find the answer, simply be.

BELOW THIS ARE DRAFTS

Compass
Feb 25, 2024

How can we know
The right way to go

The way that leads "up"
To high vistas.. fresh snow

Not the way that leads "down"
To darkness and frowns

What can we follow
What sign posts
What map

And where is the vendor
Selling the path to find that…

Well, look though you will
May not serve you until

Flying to Japan, Fall 2024

You mistake yourself for the clouds
When you are the blue sky itself

—

Do not falter my dear,
You are doing just fine.
No matter the condition
Tis all the Divine.

Do not worry my dear,
Your fears are for naught,
There is nothing in this world,
That can keep you caught

You are freedom and joy
Your heart filled with bliss
Do not worry my dear
The truth simply is this

Sometimes we can’t see it
And sometimes we forget
But don’t worry
It’s there

It never leaves you
It never pulls
But patiently waits
For the day you look within
The truth explodes all your gates

It comes pouring out of you
Through every cell of your being
The light floods you
Dissolves you
Leaves nothing to see

So let yourself go
Let the walls come crashing down
What good do they serve?
To sometimes smile, but sometimes frown

Don’t you long for the truth
Don’t you want to know God
Give up the dream
Give up the illusion
Ask for the truth
That’s all you need
You are worthy and whole
Don’t turn away from your nature
It is your truth it’s your birth

I sit and wait and think of you
Call from my heart, for what is True
Where is the calling, what is the way
God, won’t you come
And won’t you stay 🙏

I’m here, I’m open
I want to be
I try my best

I try to be

Let go he says
Let go, let go
I want to,
But my mind says no
But what's the mind
Is it me
Cannot be
Can you not see

You are God
The God within
Is swimming freely
Cannot be caged
Will always win

There is no war
There's only love
You create the struggle
Create the fight
It comes from Will
It comes from might

But lay down your arms
Put your swords at bay
Rest easy knowing
God always stays

Then you can rest and be at peace
Resting easy,

March 9th

Darling Dear
My sweet, my sound

You are loved
So why that frown

Your friends are many
Your love is deep

Do not have fear
To walk the street

These faces you see
That are passing you by

Are here to remind you
To wake up from this lie

—

April 3, 2025

Every step that I take
Let it be, in your wake
Make no mistake
This love cannot break 💖

—

October 2025

Poem Rap

Please show me the way
Please show me the light
To get through the day
To love and not fight
I don’t wanna fret
I don’t wanna fear
I just wanna to live
With no war, no tears
So how can I do it
So what shall I say
To make bad turn good
To make bad go away
I’m tired of it
It has gotten so old
To see so many hearts

Becoming so cold
Where is the warmth?
And where is the care?
Where is that love
Innocence, do we dare
To open our souls
To lay them down bare
Instead of the anger
Instead of the stares
Do you hear what I'm saying?
Do you think that it's true?
Do you even know
If it's happening to you?
The thing with it is
It happens so small
Begins with a rumble
Begins with a crawl
Just a little anger
Or just a little fear
That doesn't get noticed
That doesn't get cleared
It grows and grows
It grows in its size
And ultimately
It leads to demise
So you listen up
Don't ignore, this is true
This phenomenon
It happens in you
And you want to live
In peace and in love
So put down that hatred
And put down those gloves
It's time to change course
It's time to turn back
To a different way
To a different track
This one is of kindness
This one is of love
This path is called holy
It's sent from above
It leads us to truth
And it leads us to care
It lets go of doubt

It makes us lay bare
It opens our hearts
And it opens our minds
It washes the anger
And it makes us kind
To see one another
Our filters removed
Finally we realize
There's nothing to prove
This person's no more
And this person's no less
This person's the same
Different shoes, different dress
But that's all that it is
This story we made
Describing the world
And all of its shades
It can be erased
Can be put to the grave
And that's what is needed
And that's what we gotta do
Gotta put down our stories
Cause none are quite true
It's time for us to see
It's time for us to know
How to live life fulfilled
Not to live life for show
So if you're ready for this
Then it's easy you see
All you gotta do
Is simply to be